MARS
HEROICALLY UNQUALIFIED
01 / FLOOR IS THE ENEMY

MARS

HEROICALLY UNQUALIFIED

Volume 1 · Floor Is the Enemy

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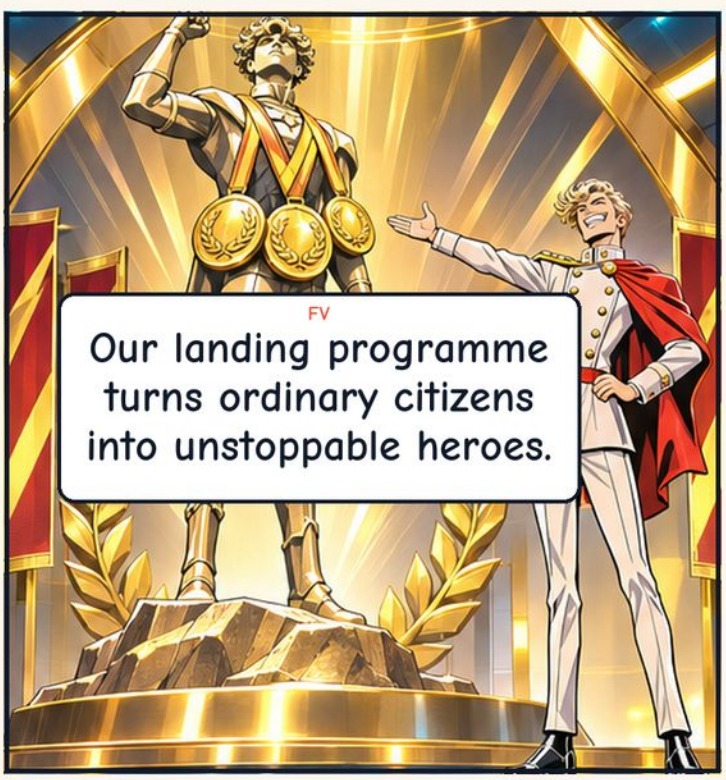
FV
Citizens! Earth is heavy. Your courage need not be.
MARS · 2705

FV
One brave step can change the course of history.


FV
Our landing programme turns ordinary citizens into unstoppable heroes.

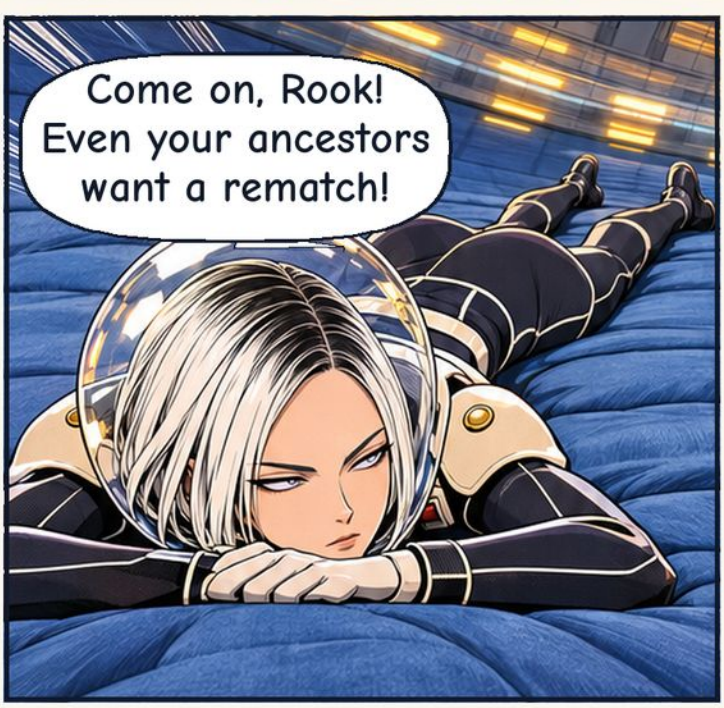
FV
Train today. Stand tomorrow. Make your entire planet proud.

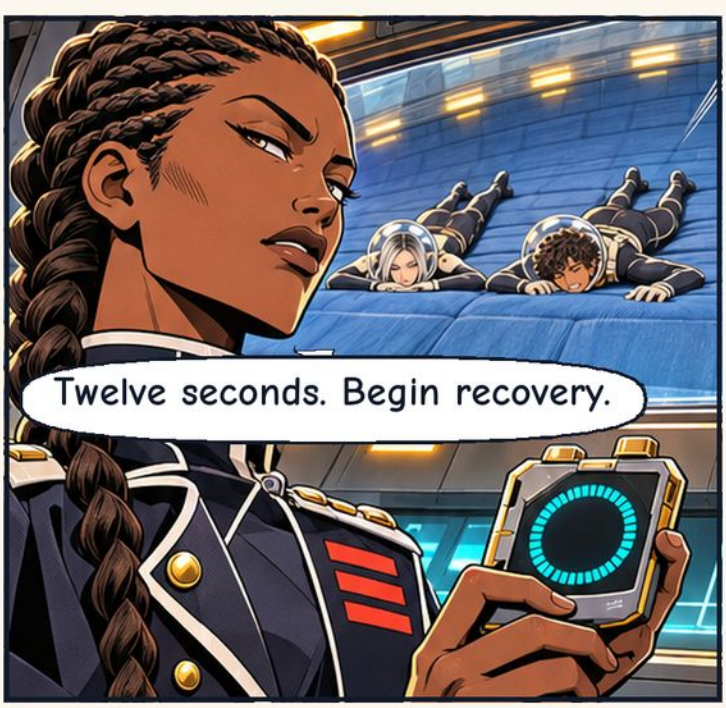
FV
Stay bright. Stay Martian. Gravity is only an attitude.

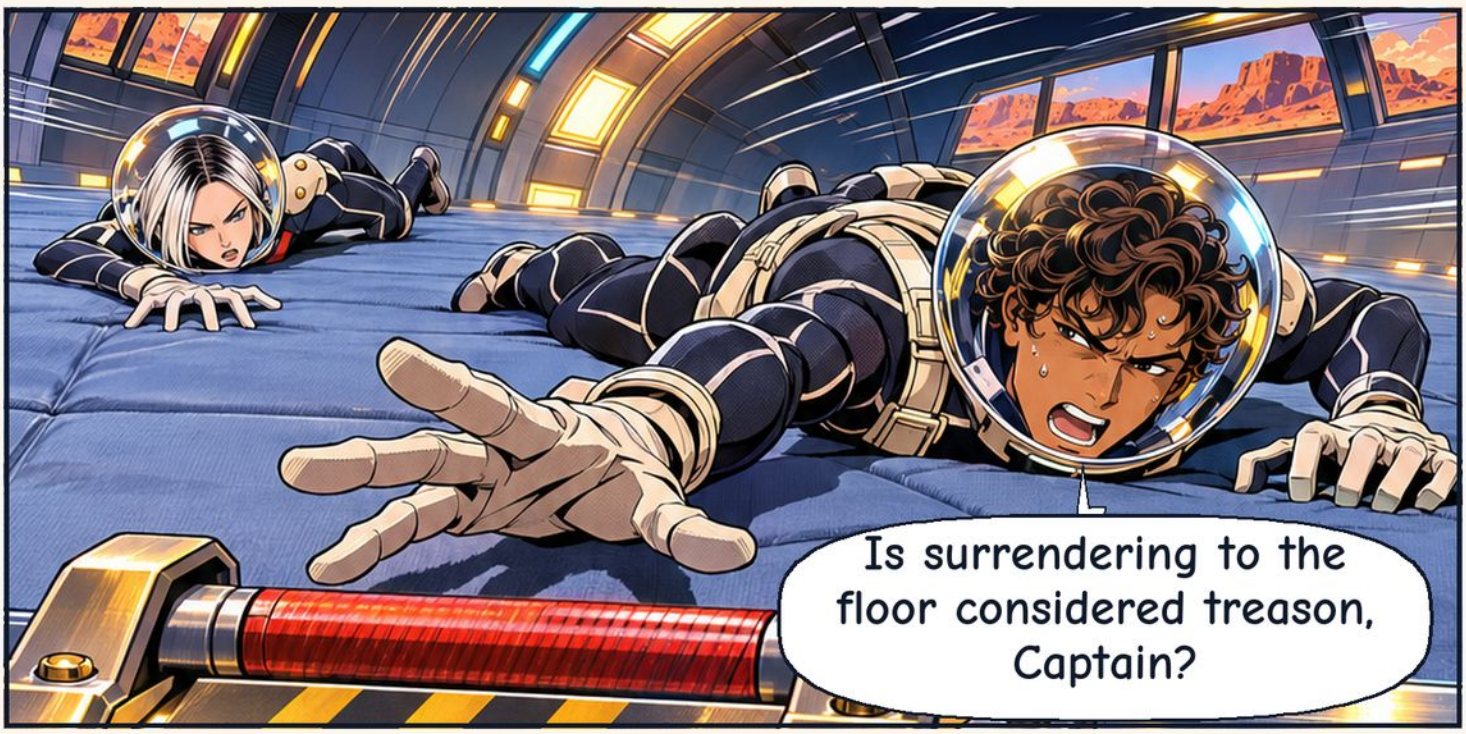
Watch closely. I have been standing successfully for years.

Hey, were any of those years on the heavy setting?

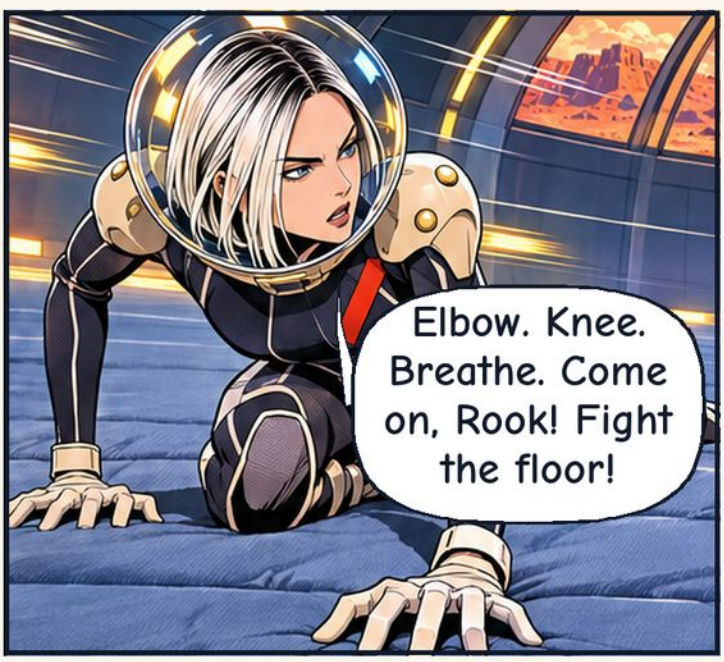
I can feel my ancestors. They want me horizontal.
THUD


Come on, Rook! Even your ancestors want a rematch!

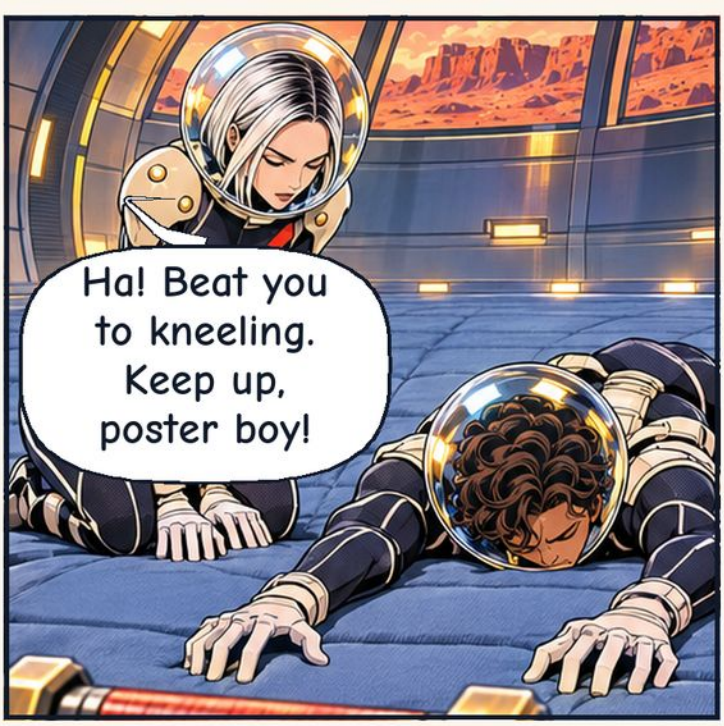

Twelve seconds. Begin recovery.


Is surrendering to the floor considered treason, Captain?

Only if you tell it where we keep the biscuits.


Elbow. Knee. Breathe. Come on, Rook! Fight the floor!

FV
Observe the tactical hug! A bold embrace of hostile terrain!

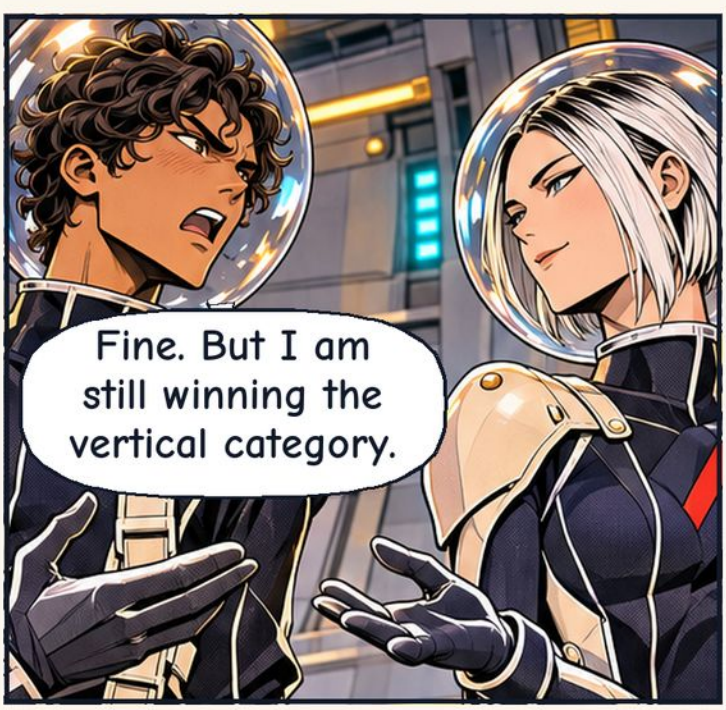

Ha! Beat you to kneeling. Keep up, poster boy!

I had that under control. The floor moved unexpectedly.

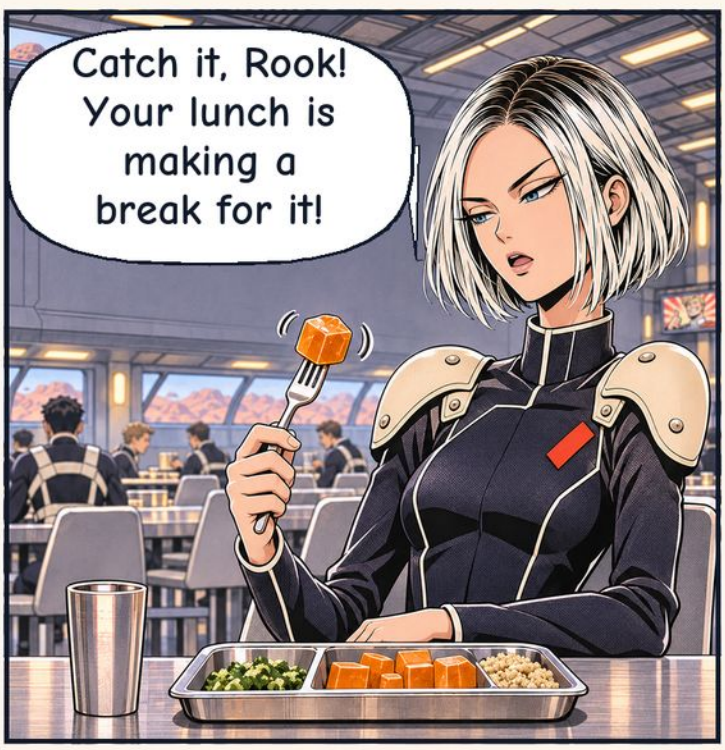
Take my hand, show-off! I am not losing to flooring!

COMMS / SERA
Brace first. Then reach.

Same assignment. Work together.


Fine. But I am still winning the vertical category.

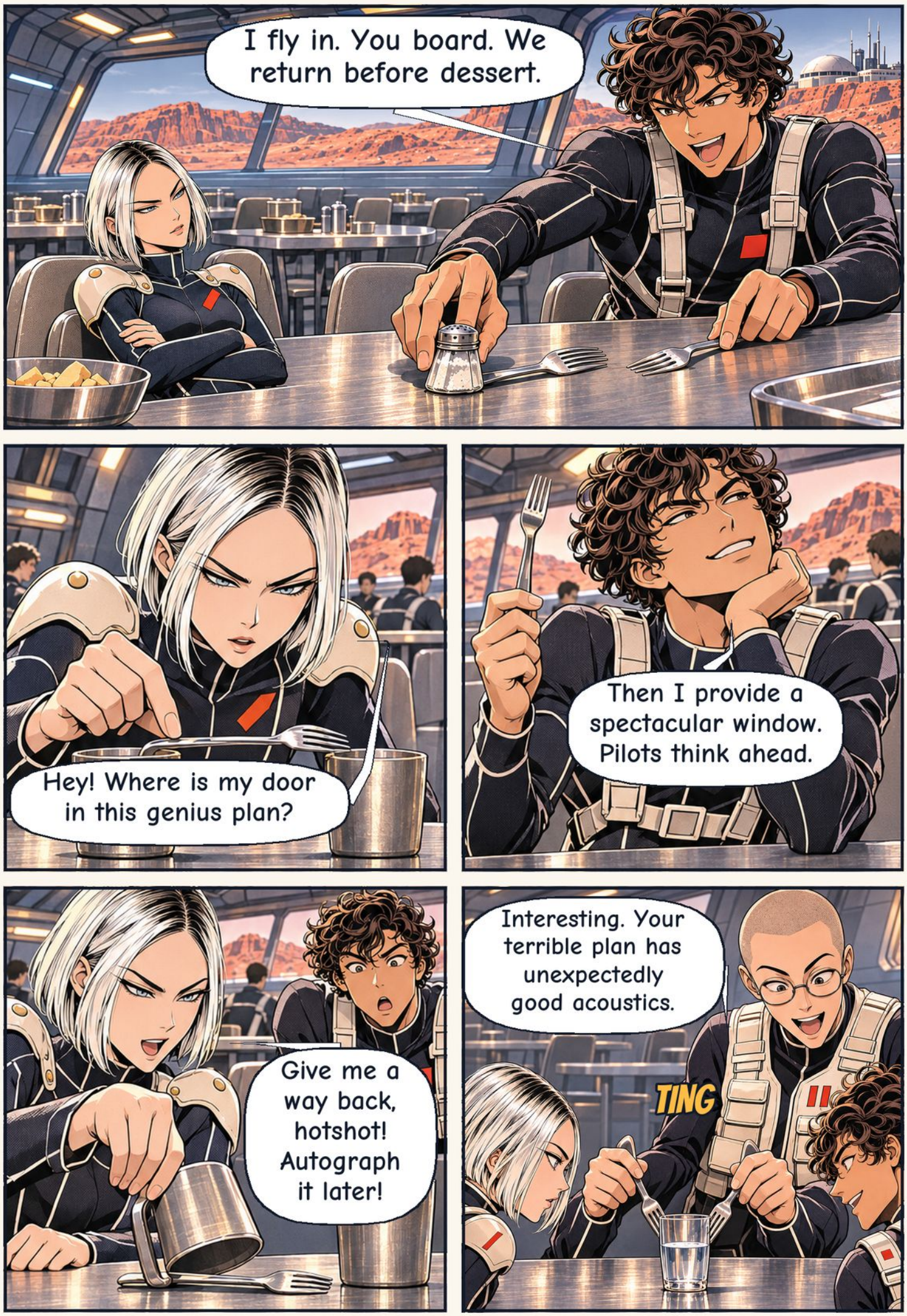
First mission. First rescue. I can almost hear the applause.

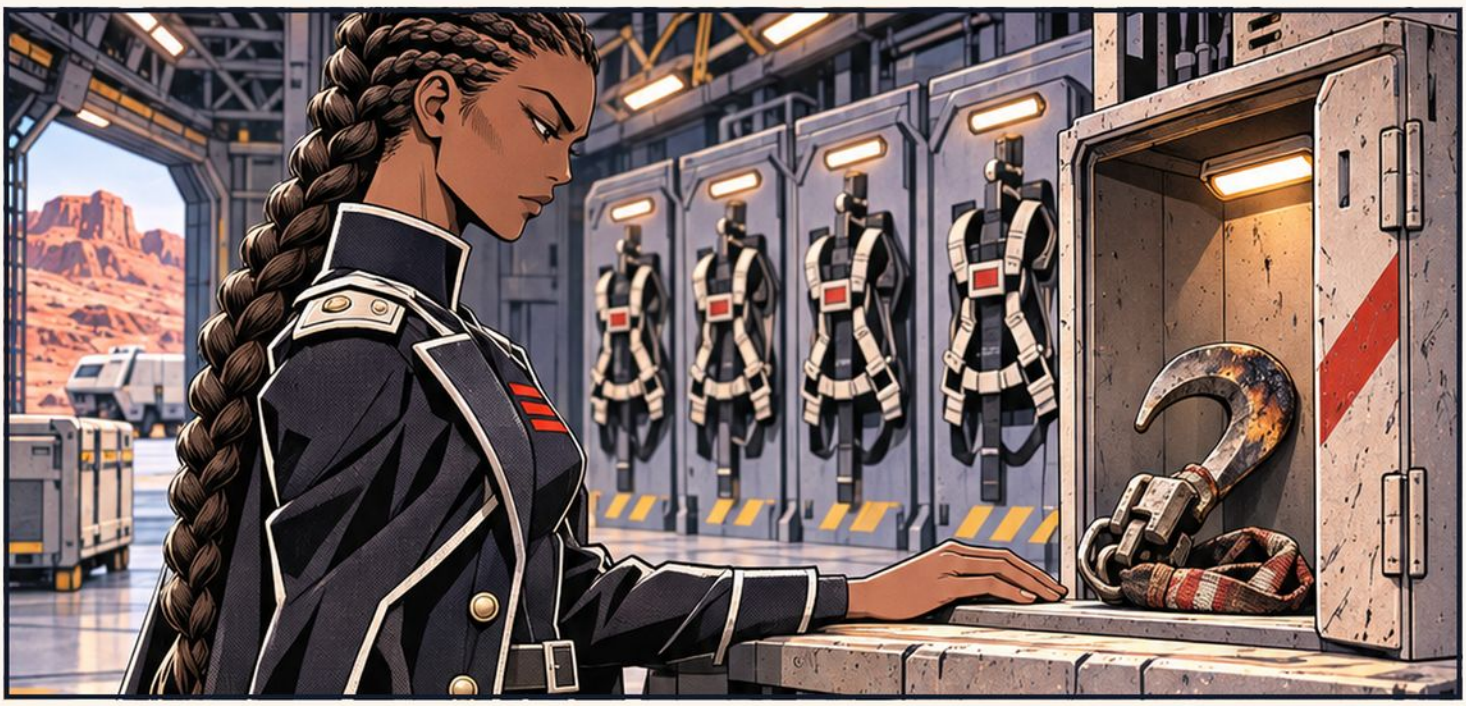

Catch it, Rook! Your lunch is making a break for it!

Please do not eat anything from the blue case.

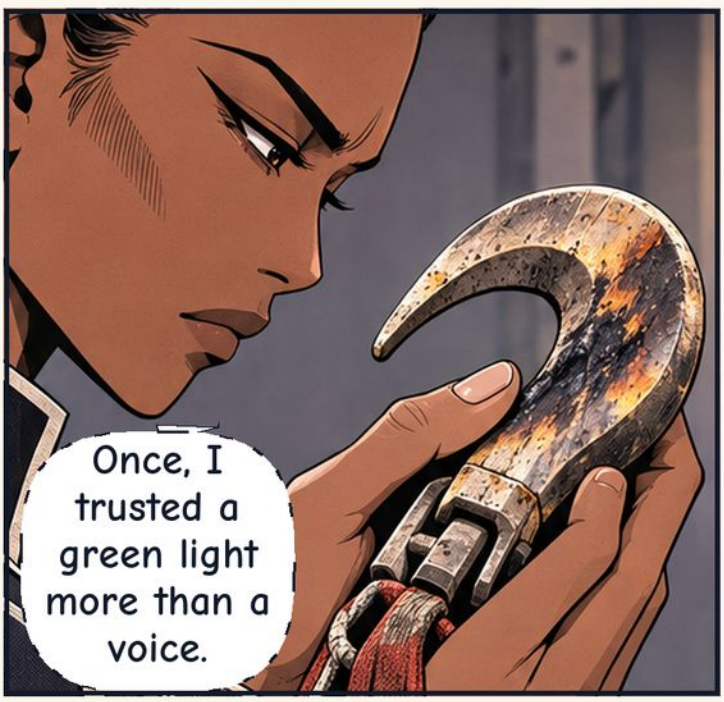
That is a seal washer. Technically, it contains minerals.

Yes! Finally, a meal I can build a barricade with!


I fly in. You board. We return before dessert.
Hey! Where is my door in this genius plan?
Then I provide a spectacular window. Pilots think ahead.
Give me a way back, hotshot! Autograph it later!
Interesting. Your terrible plan has unexpectedly good acoustics.
TING

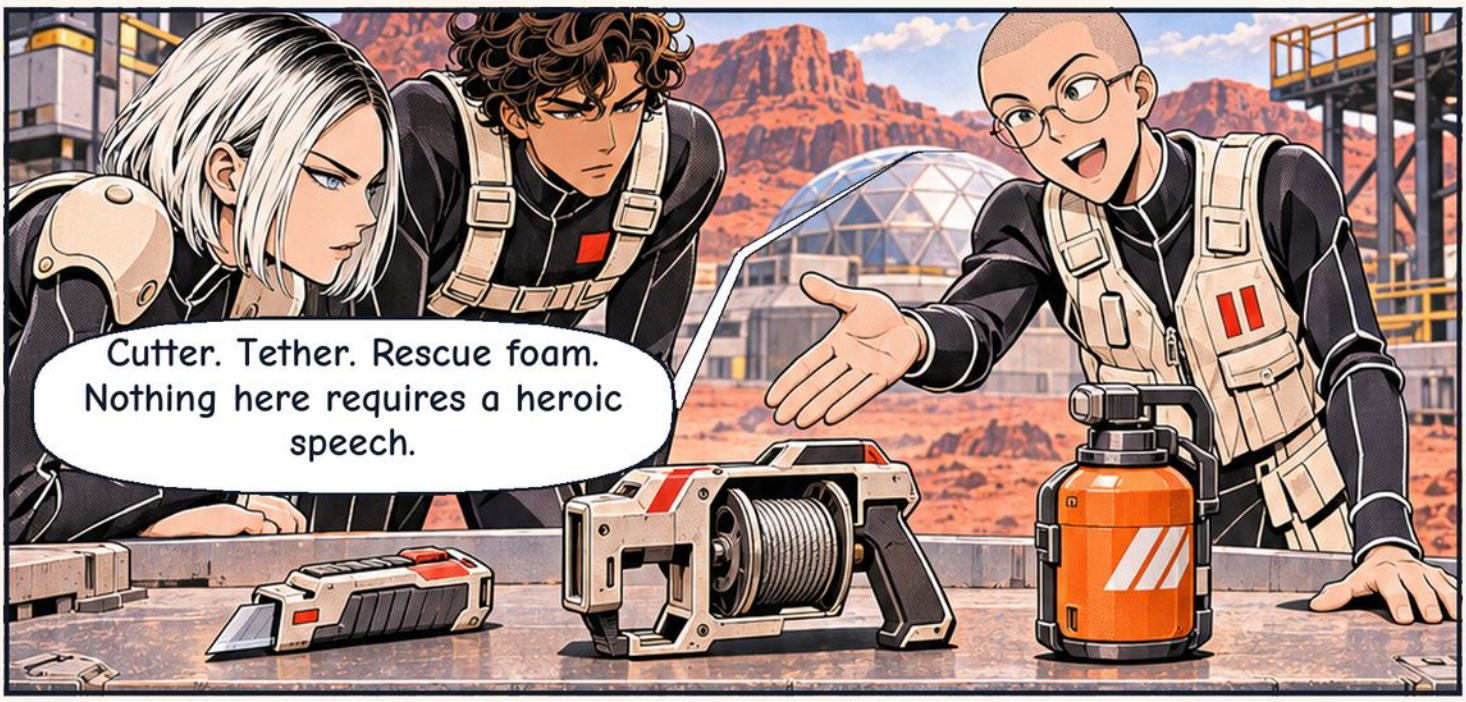


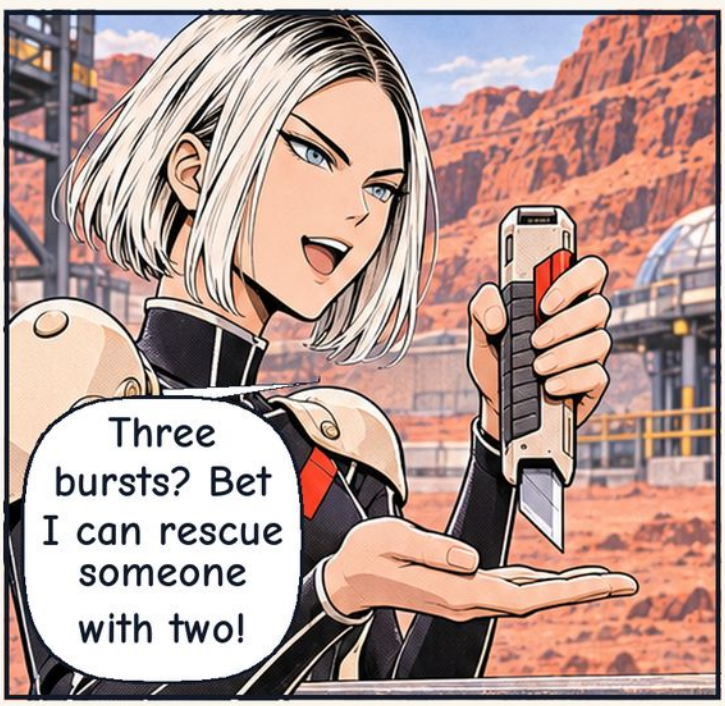
You check every tether yourself? Even the new ones?

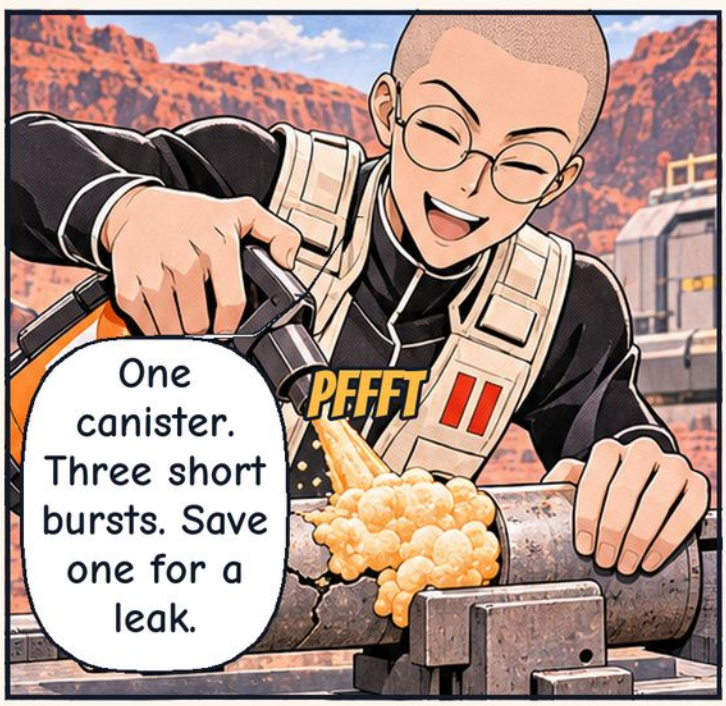

Once, I trusted a green light more than a voice.

Answer when I call.

Count on it! You will hear me all the way home.

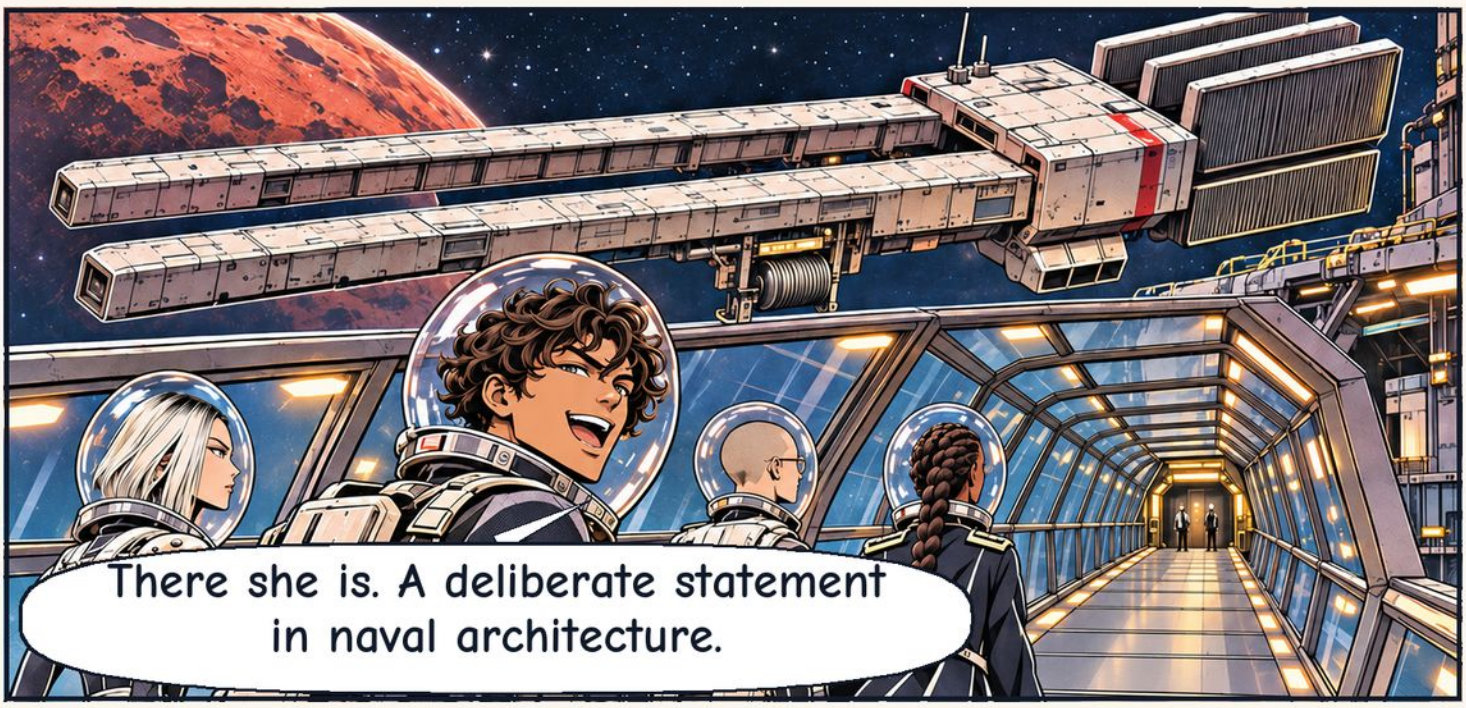

Cutter. Tether. Rescue foam. Nothing here requires a heroic speech.

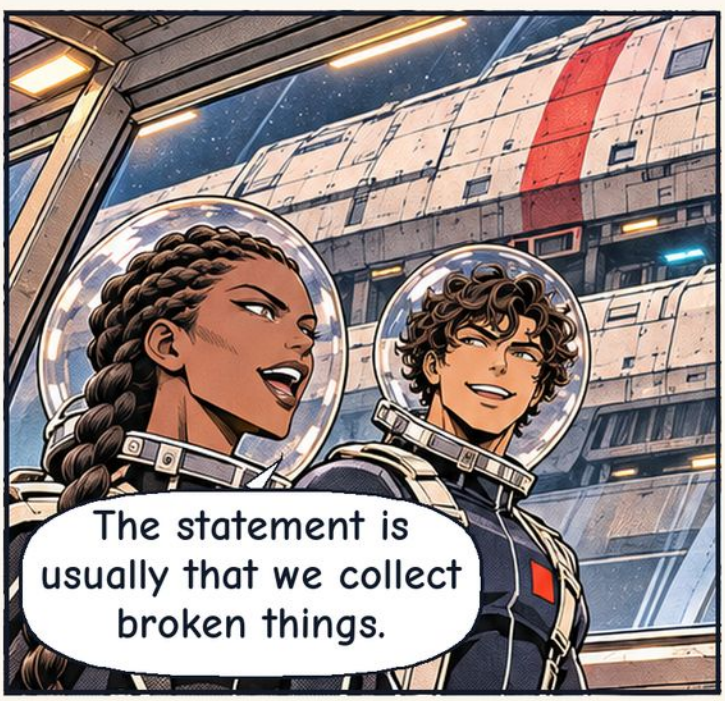

Three bursts? Bet I can rescue someone with two!


PFFFT
One canister. Three short bursts. Save one for a leak.

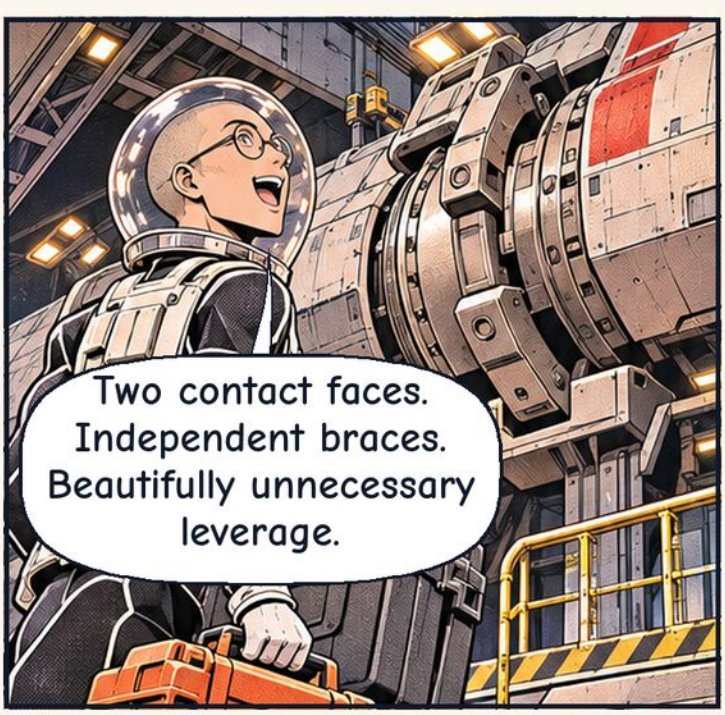
I brought my own. Top marks in equipment presentation.

Buckle your leg strap.

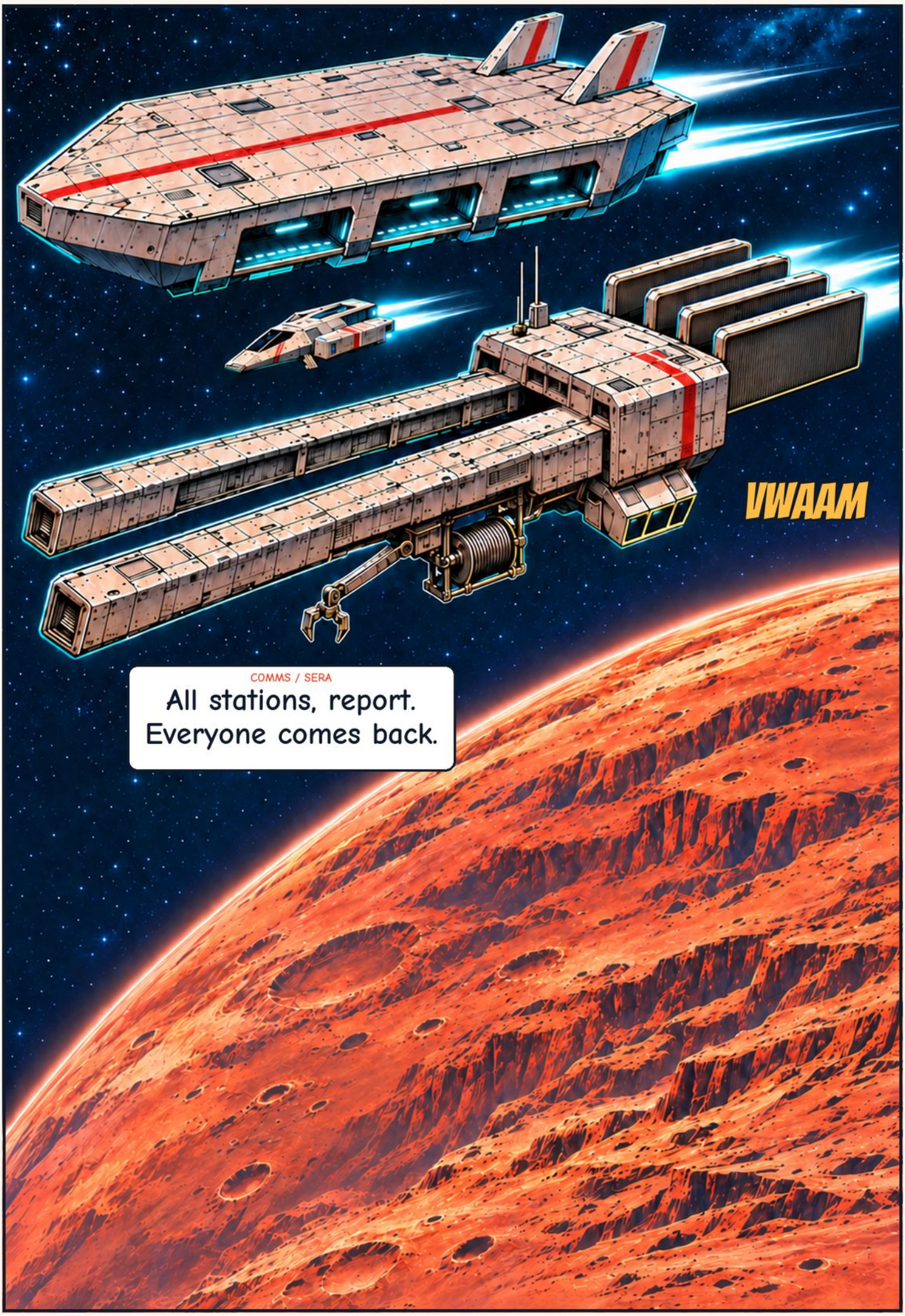

There she is. A deliberate statement in naval architecture.

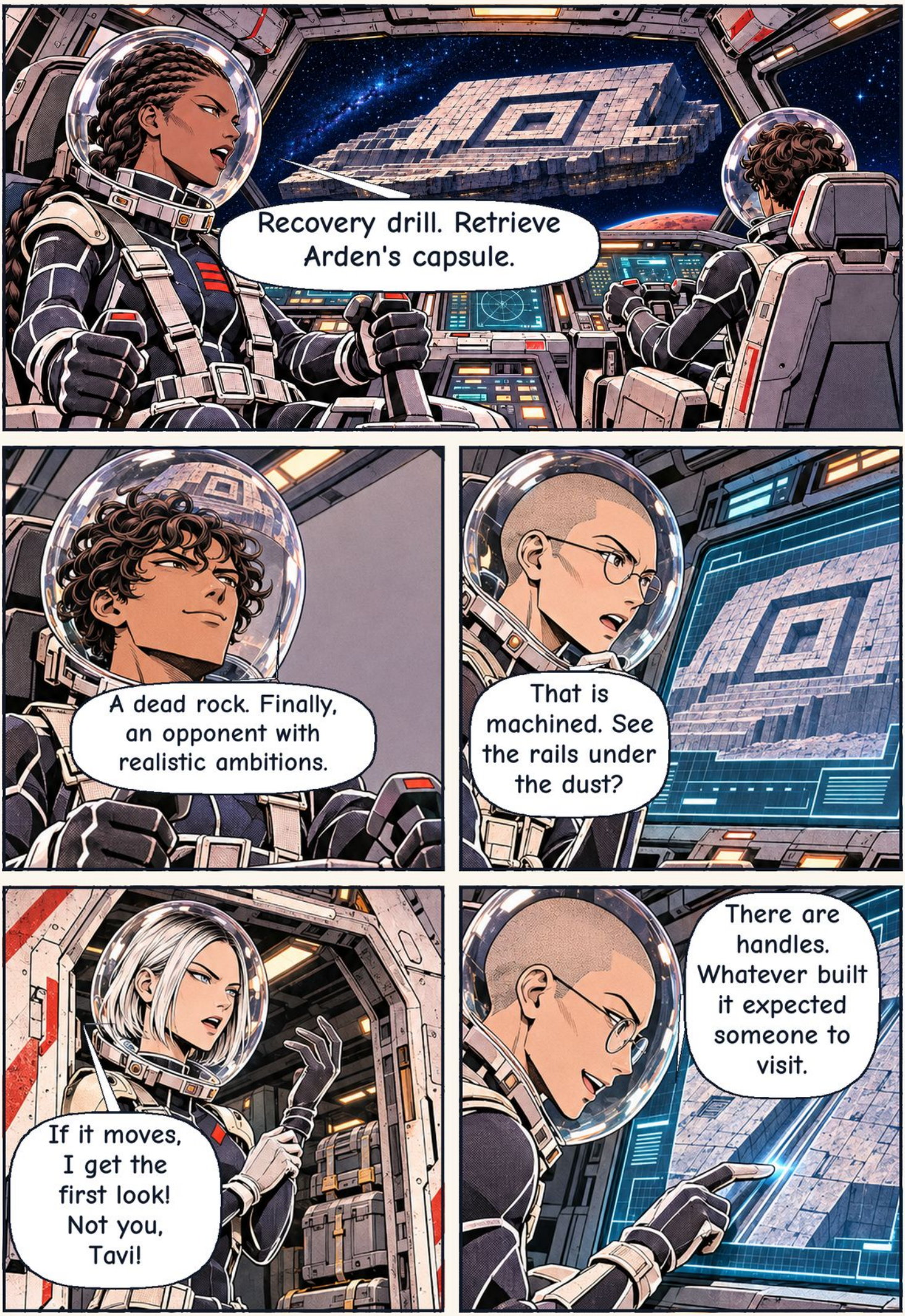

The statement is usually that we collect broken things.

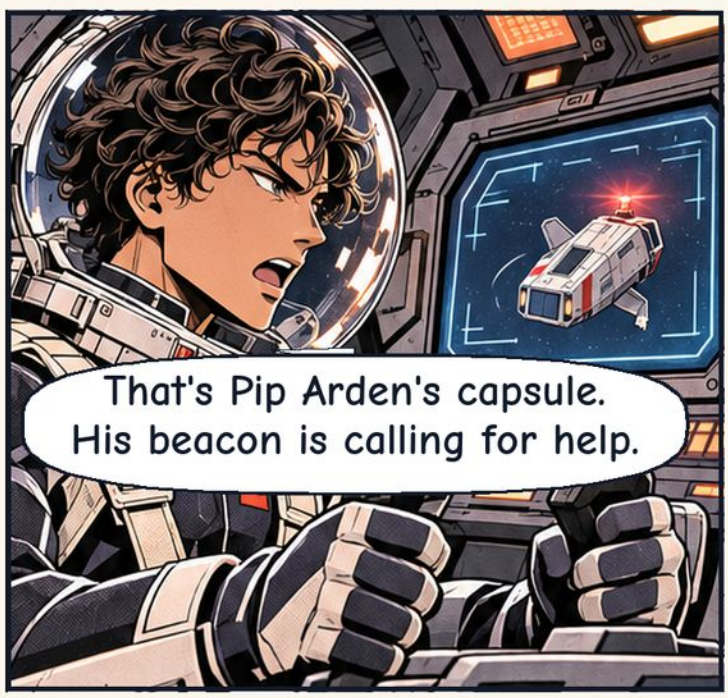
Look at those forks! Rook, dare you to park backwards!

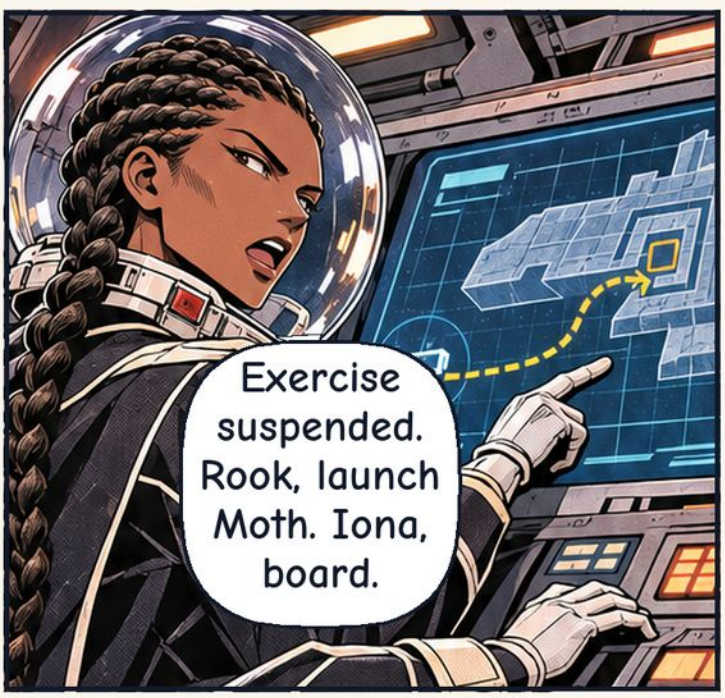

Two contact faces. Independent braces. Beautifully unnecessary leverage.

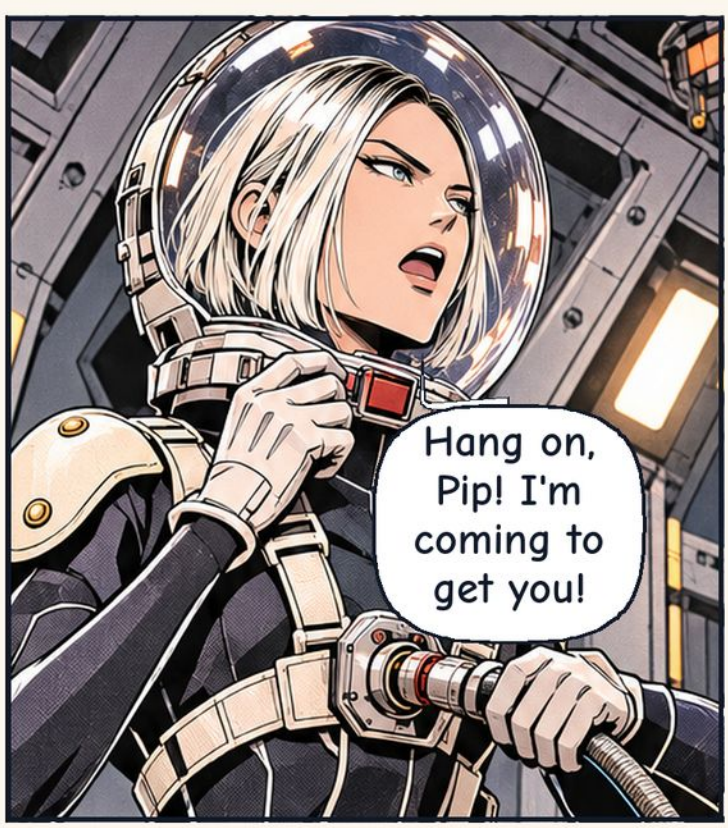
Exactly. A rescue ship with the silhouette of confidence.


VWAAM
COMMS / SERA
All stations, report. Everyone comes back.


Recovery drill. Retrieve Arden's capsule.
A dead rock. Finally, an opponent with realistic ambitions.
That is machined. See the rails under the dust?
If it moves, I get the first look! Not you, Tavi!
There are handles. Whatever built it expected someone to visit.

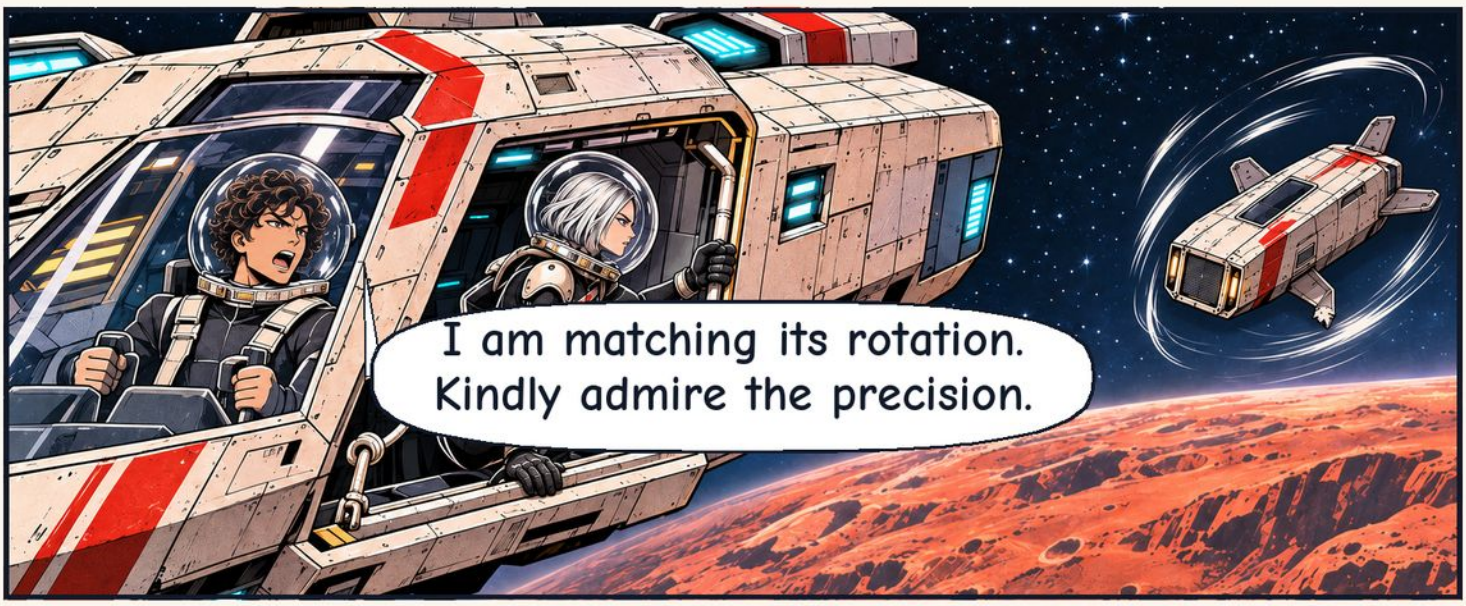

That's Pip Arden's capsule. His beacon is calling for help.

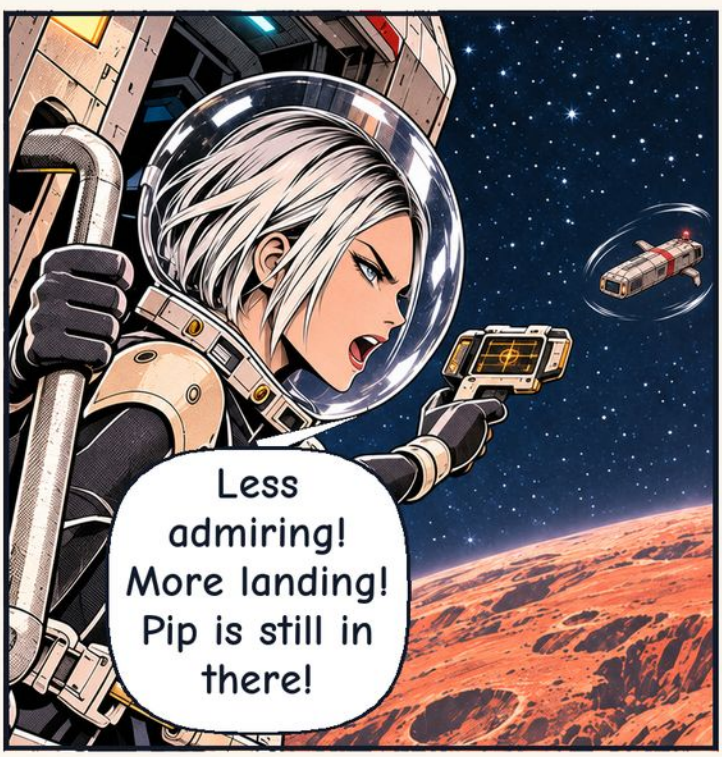

Exercise suspended. Rook, launch Moth. Iona, board.


Hang on, Pip! I'm coming to get you!

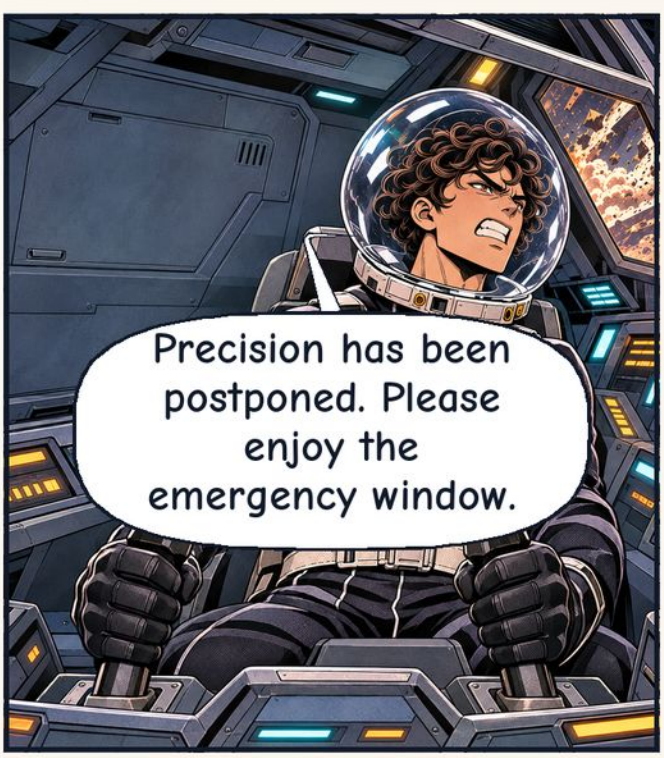
I'm pinned! Please hurry. I am failing independent study.

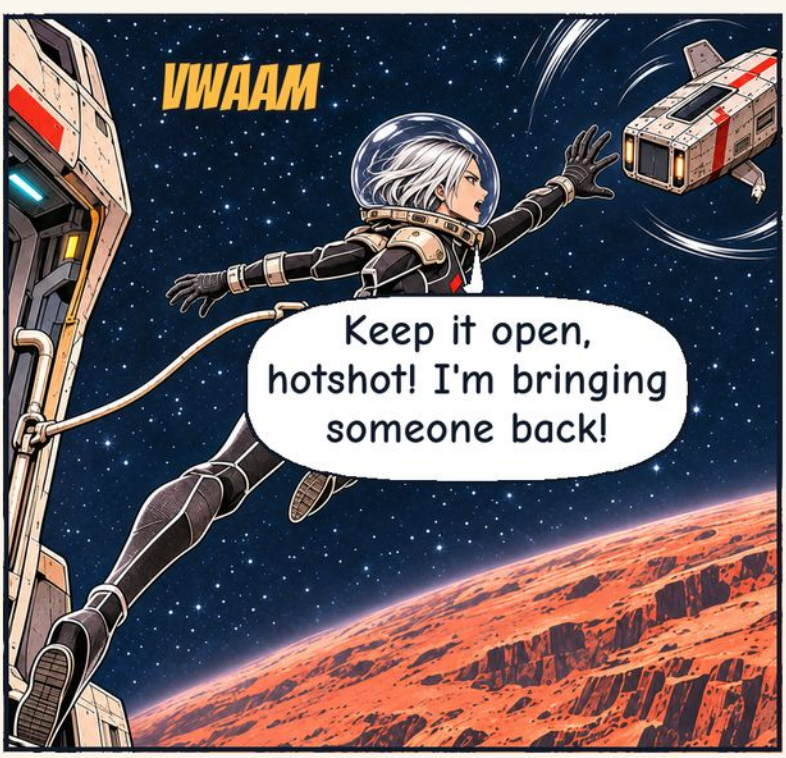
FV
Training break! Join our proud fleet in the victory refrain!
TIK
Those lights just answered the programme. Play that again.
Mute it. Rescue first.
SHUNK
Oh, come on! Pick a worse time to wake up!


I am matching its rotation. Kindly admire the precision.


Less admiring! More landing! Pip is still in there!

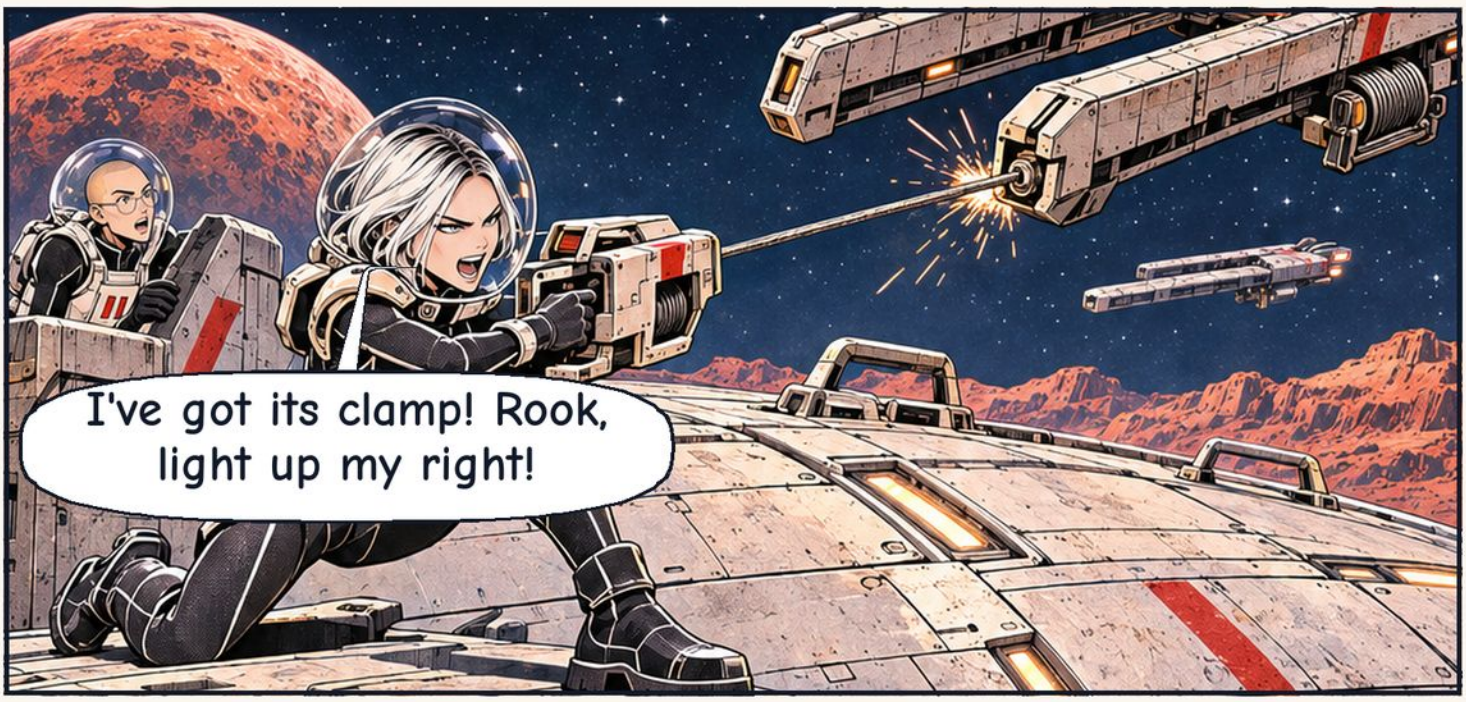
KRAKOOM


Precision has been postponed. Please enjoy the emergency window.


VWAAM
Keep it open, hotshot! I'm bringing someone back!

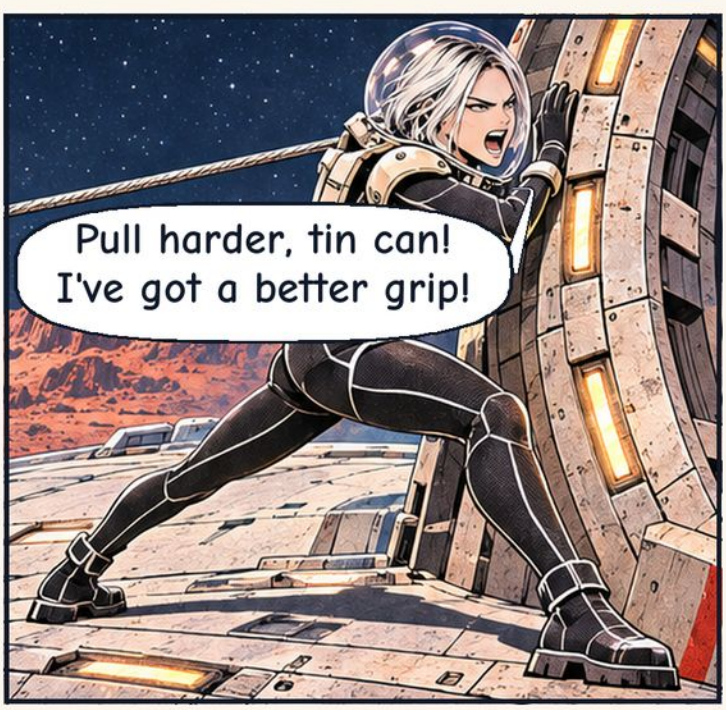
KLANG
I'm on! Pip, can you hear me? Stay with me!
Coming across.
Please leave something recognisable for me to study.
Pip! Eyes on me! I'm cutting you out!
SHUNK
Got you, Pip! Rook, take him! The dummy stays with us!

Service drones. They are probably clearing the work area.
Hey, scrap heap! Try picking on someone with a cutter!
Technically, we are standing where its next plate goes.
KRAK
Move! I am nobody's spare elbow!

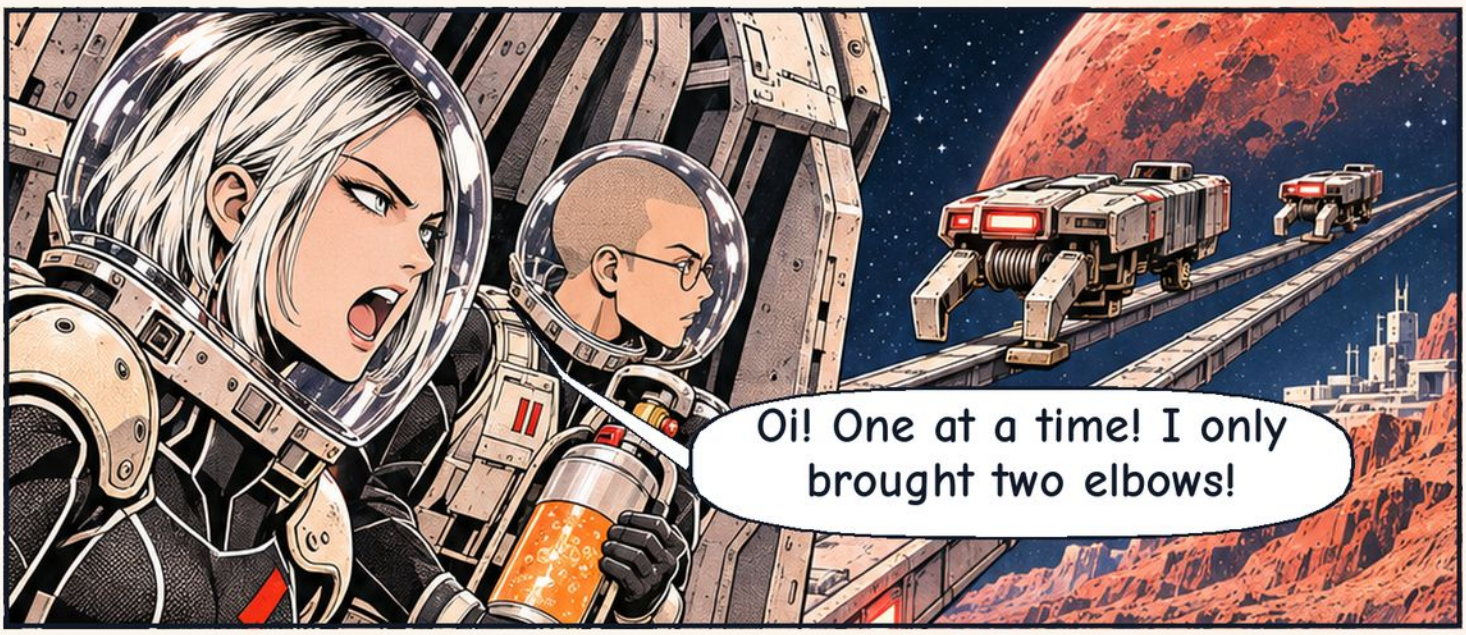

I've got its clamp! Rook, light up my right!

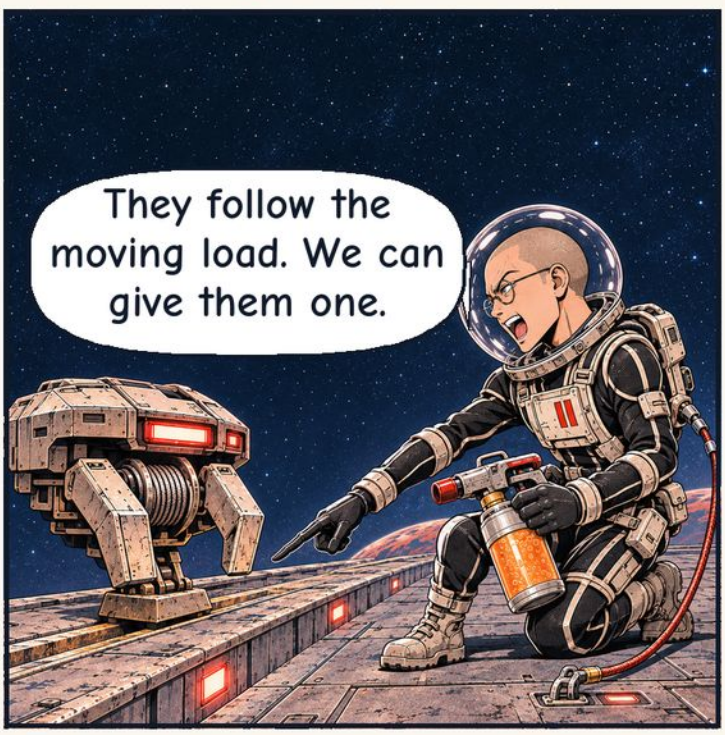
Covering. With light. Our weapons package is mostly optimism.

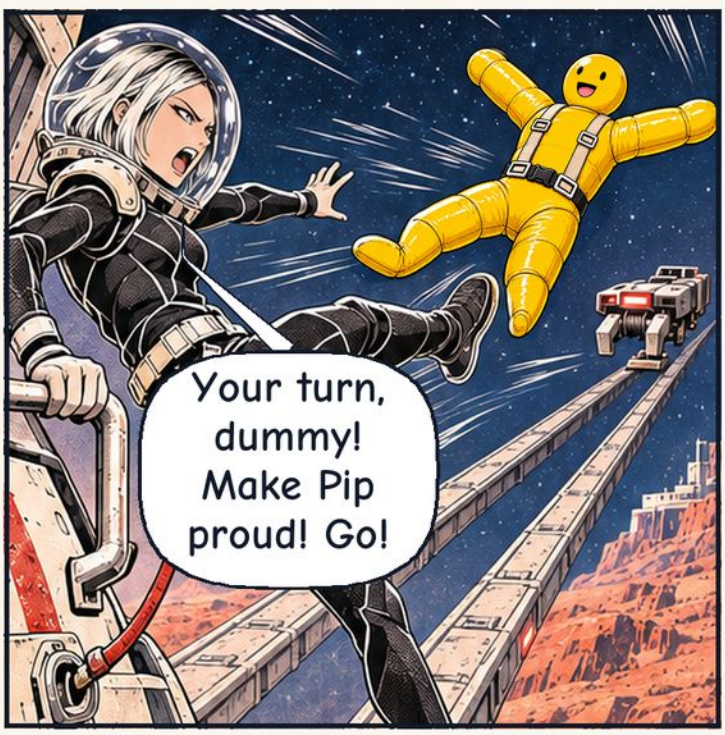
There! Its feet stop when that rail goes dark.

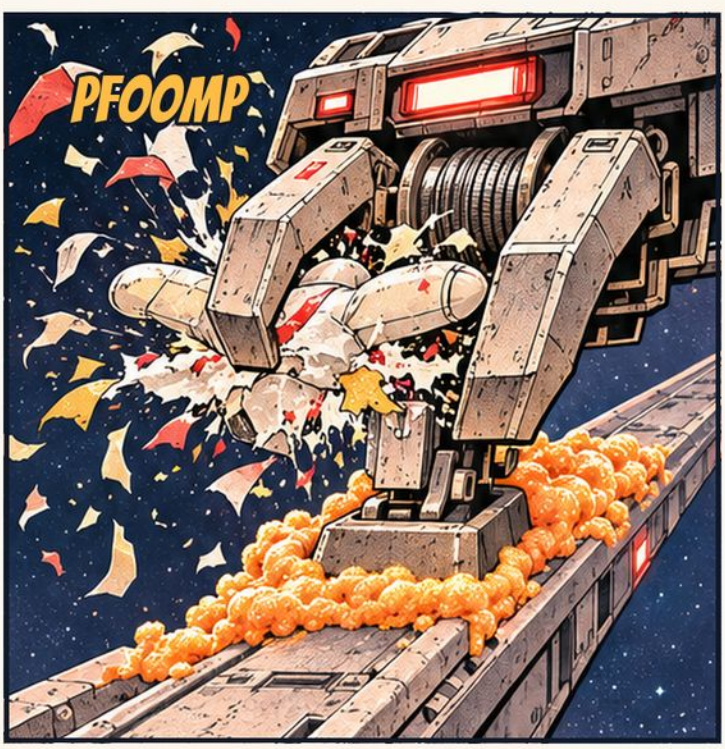

Pull harder, tin can! I've got a better grip!

CHAK
Hold that line. It is waiting for the rail to clear.

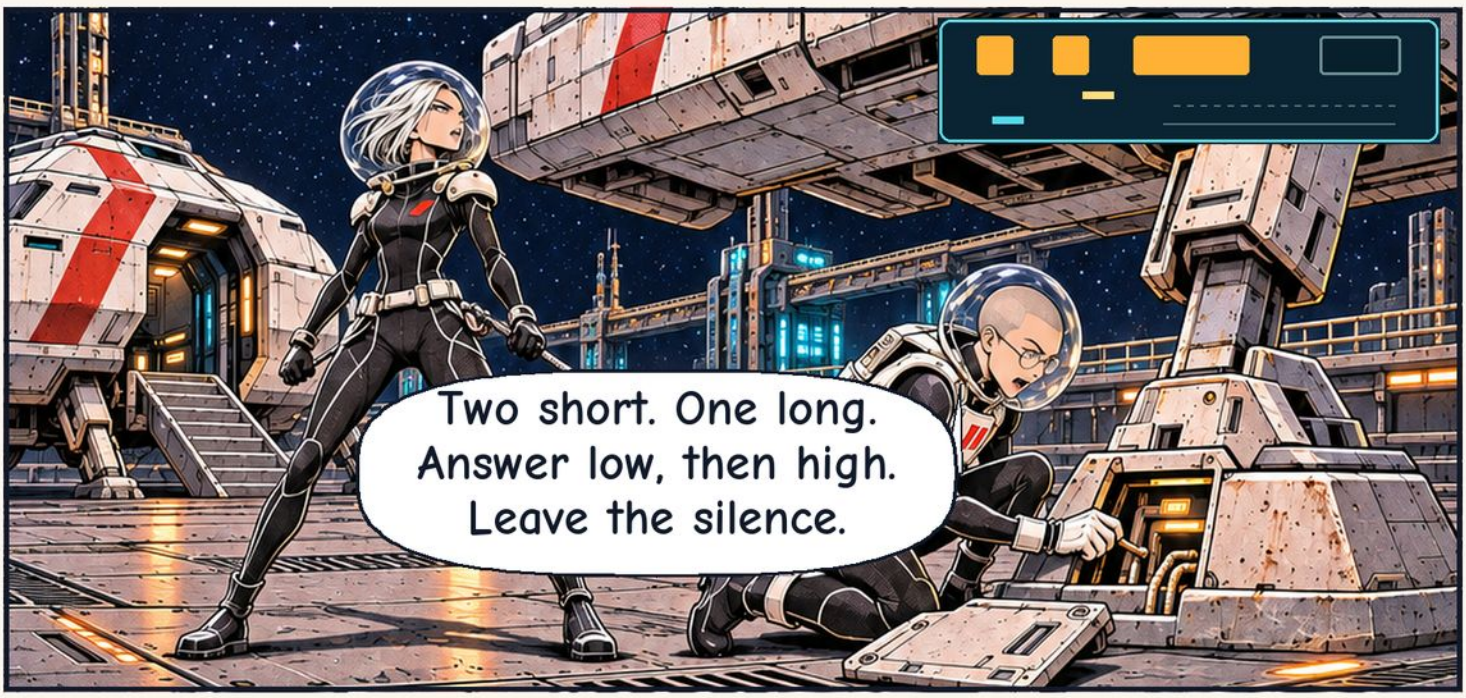

Oi! One at a time! I only brought two elbows!

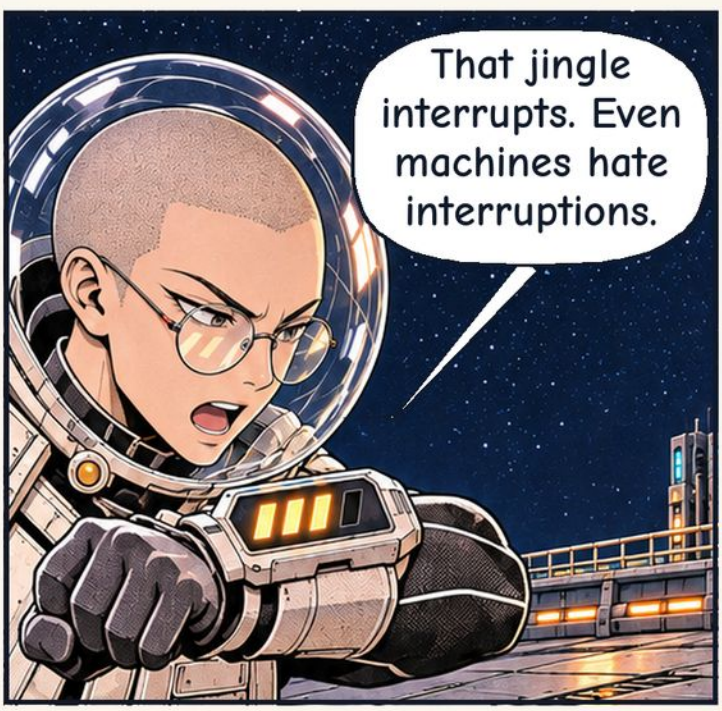

They follow the moving load. We can give them one.


Your turn, dummy! Make Pip proud! Go!

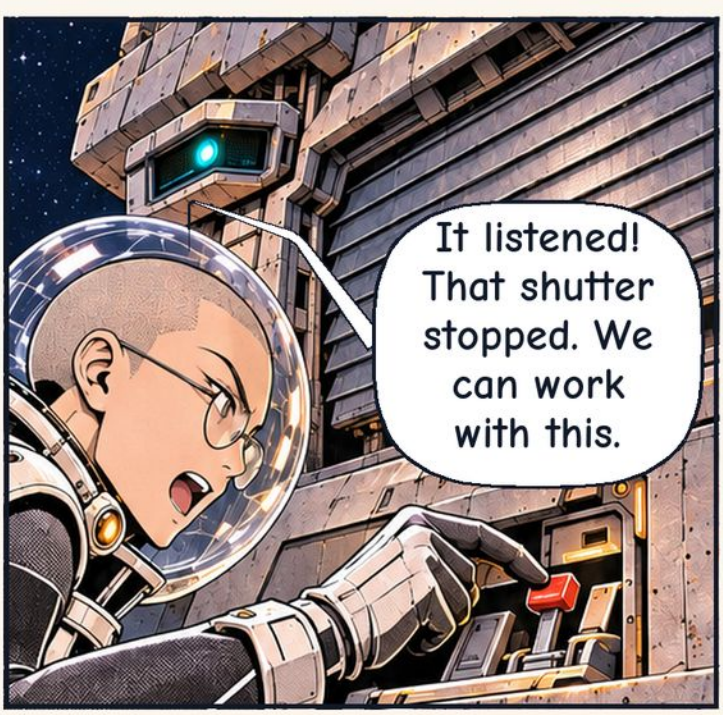

PFOOMP

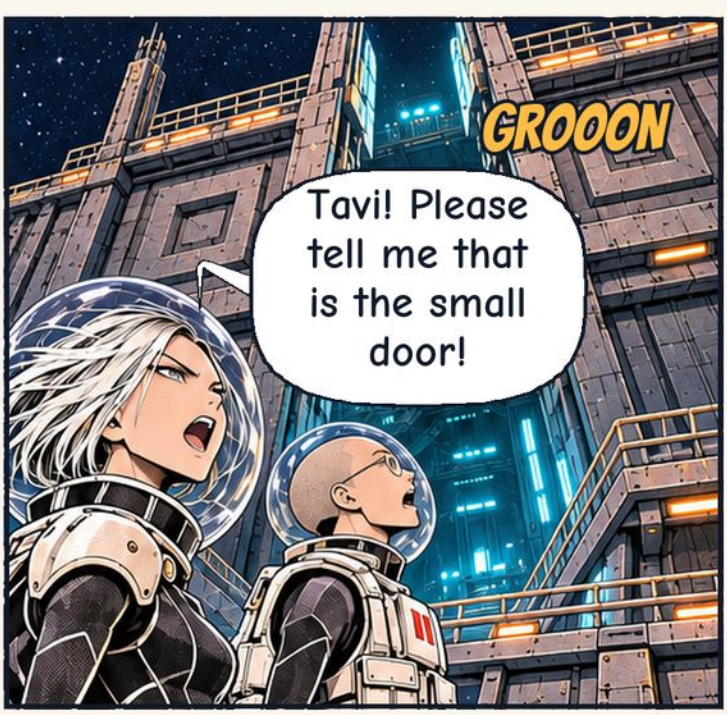
He served for eighteen seconds. I will write the speech.


Two short. One long. Answer low, then high. Leave the silence.


That jingle interrupts. Even machines hate interruptions.

Great! Can you make it listen before I lose this shield?
KLANG


It listened! That shutter stopped. We can work with this.

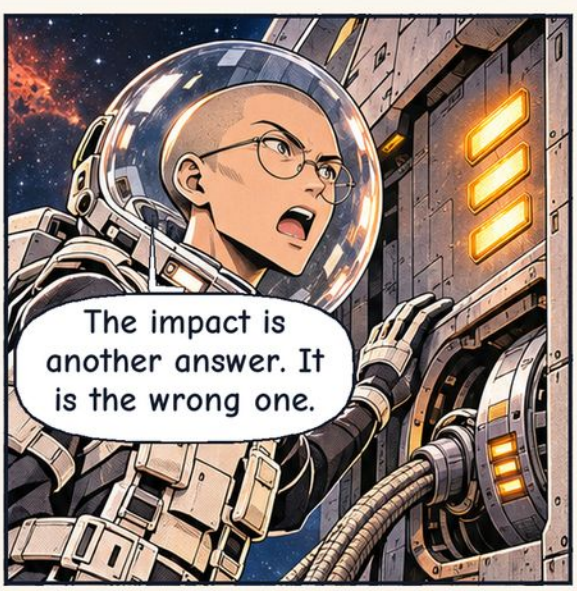

GROOON
Tavi! Please tell me that is the small door!

GROOON
COMMS / TAVI
We have been fighting a doorbell. That is the house.

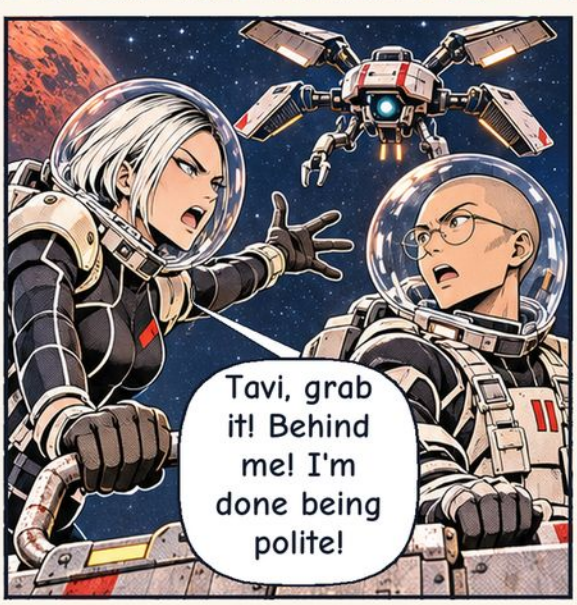
COMMS / COMMANDER
Civic Mercy, expedition command! Earth attack! Beam said stay bright. Open fire!

KRAKOOM

Cease fire. Cadets inside.


The impact is another answer. It is the wrong one.

The house has noticed us. It would like its door back.

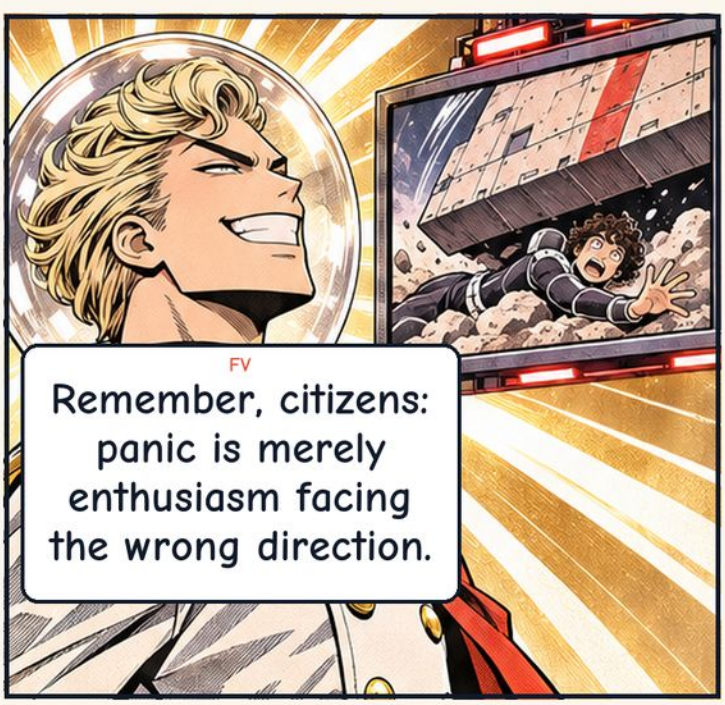

Tavi, grab it! Behind me! I'm done being polite!

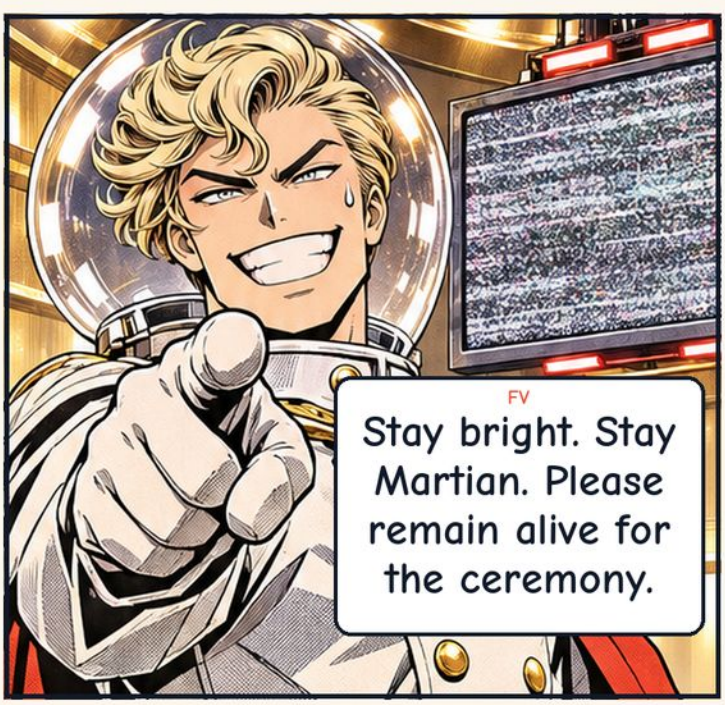
This is the local governor. Removing it buys one pause.
One pause. Not a shutdown. We should already be leaving.
Got it! Leaving! Tell the clamps I said bite me!
VWAAM
PIP / LIVE
Iona. Tavi. Rook. Pip. Report.

FV
Excellent news! Our training exercise has acquired unprecedented educational value!

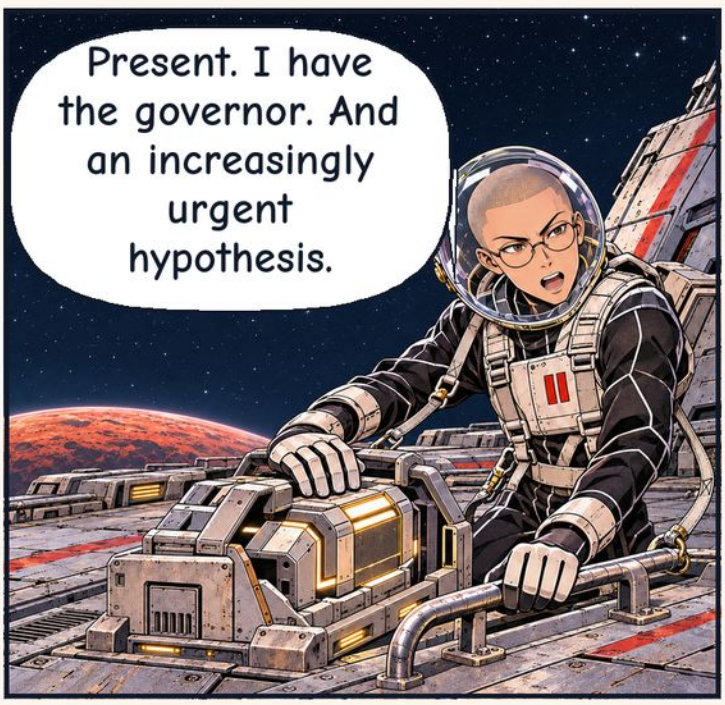
FV
Those are not explosions. Those are opportunities becoming extremely visible.

FV
Every survivor qualifies for our new Medal of Upright Excellence.


FV
Remember, citizens: panic is merely enthusiasm facing the wrong direction.


FV
Stay bright. Stay Martian. Please remain alive for the ceremony.

Present! Still here! That clamp is going to regret it!

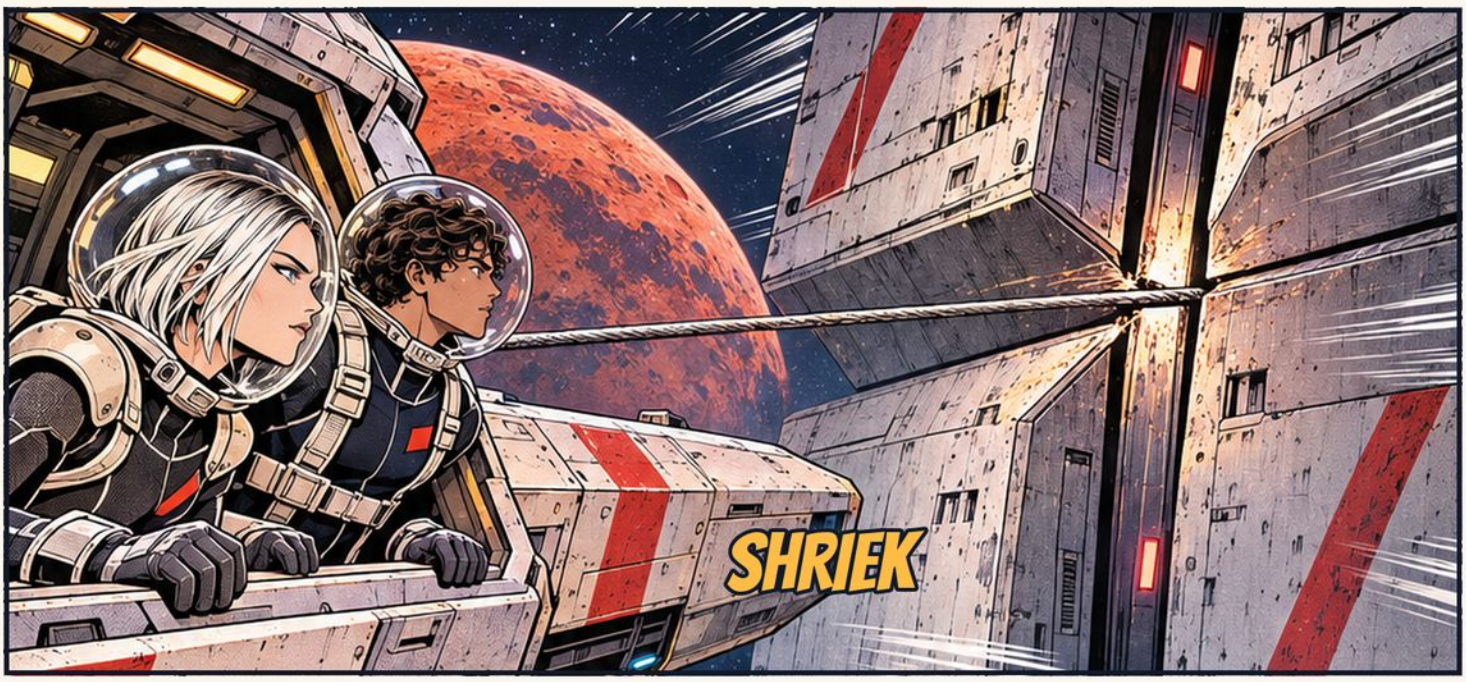

Present. I have the governor. And an increasingly urgent hypothesis.

Present. I cannot hold this corridor. I need another route.

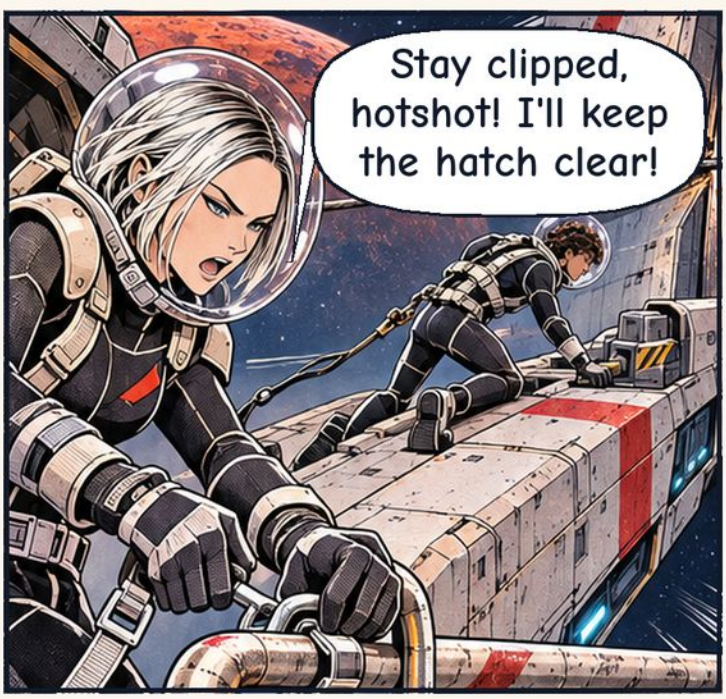
Your limits. Tell me.

I can put the hatch behind that rib. For one beat.

Your turn, Tavi! Move! I've got these scrap heaps!
COMMS / PIP
Here, Captain. Belt tight.
KRAK
Your route back. Delivered exactly where you requested it.
Yes! That's my pilot! Tell anyone and we're racing again!


SHRIEK

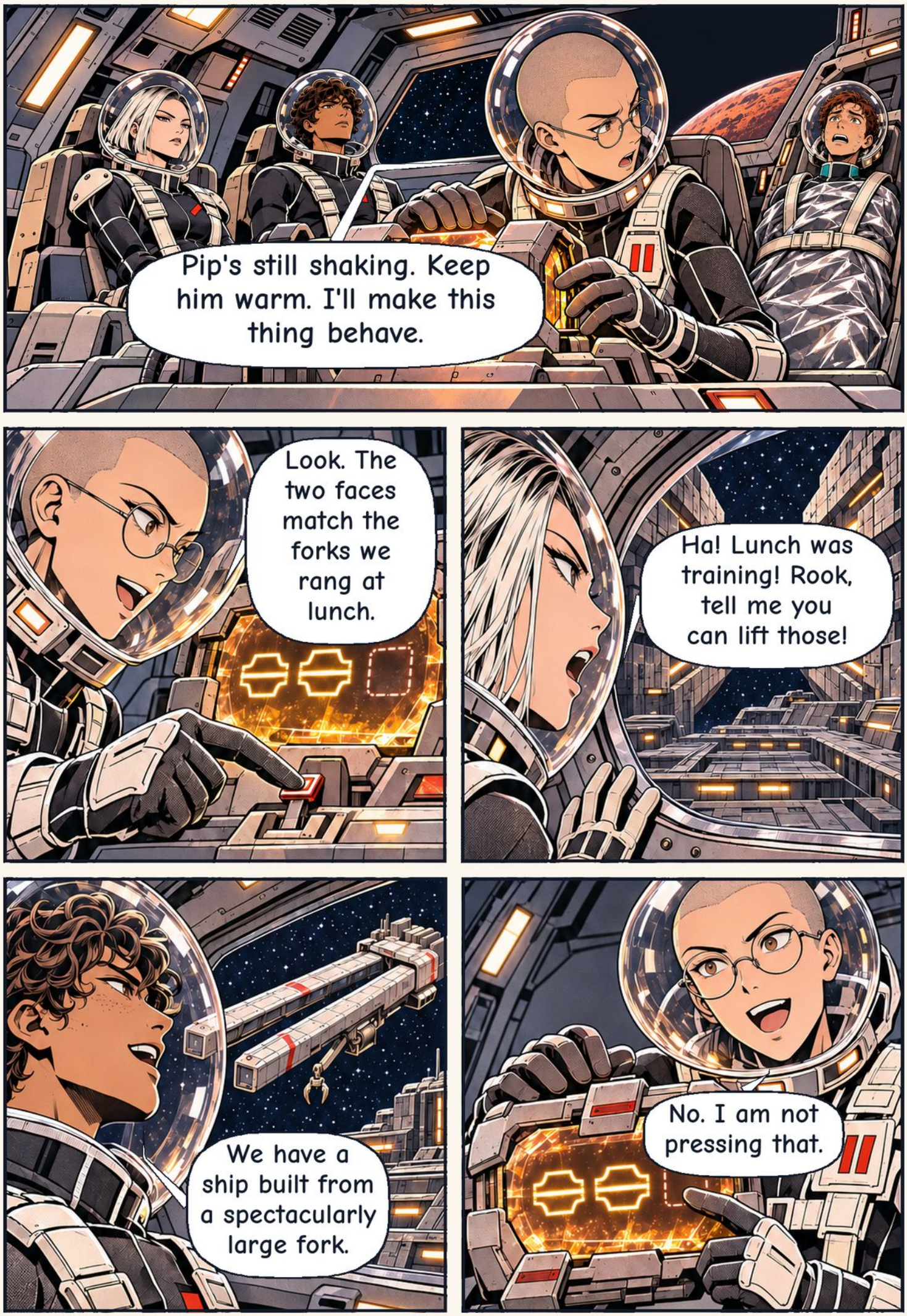
Towline snagged. We cut it or the whole launch goes in.

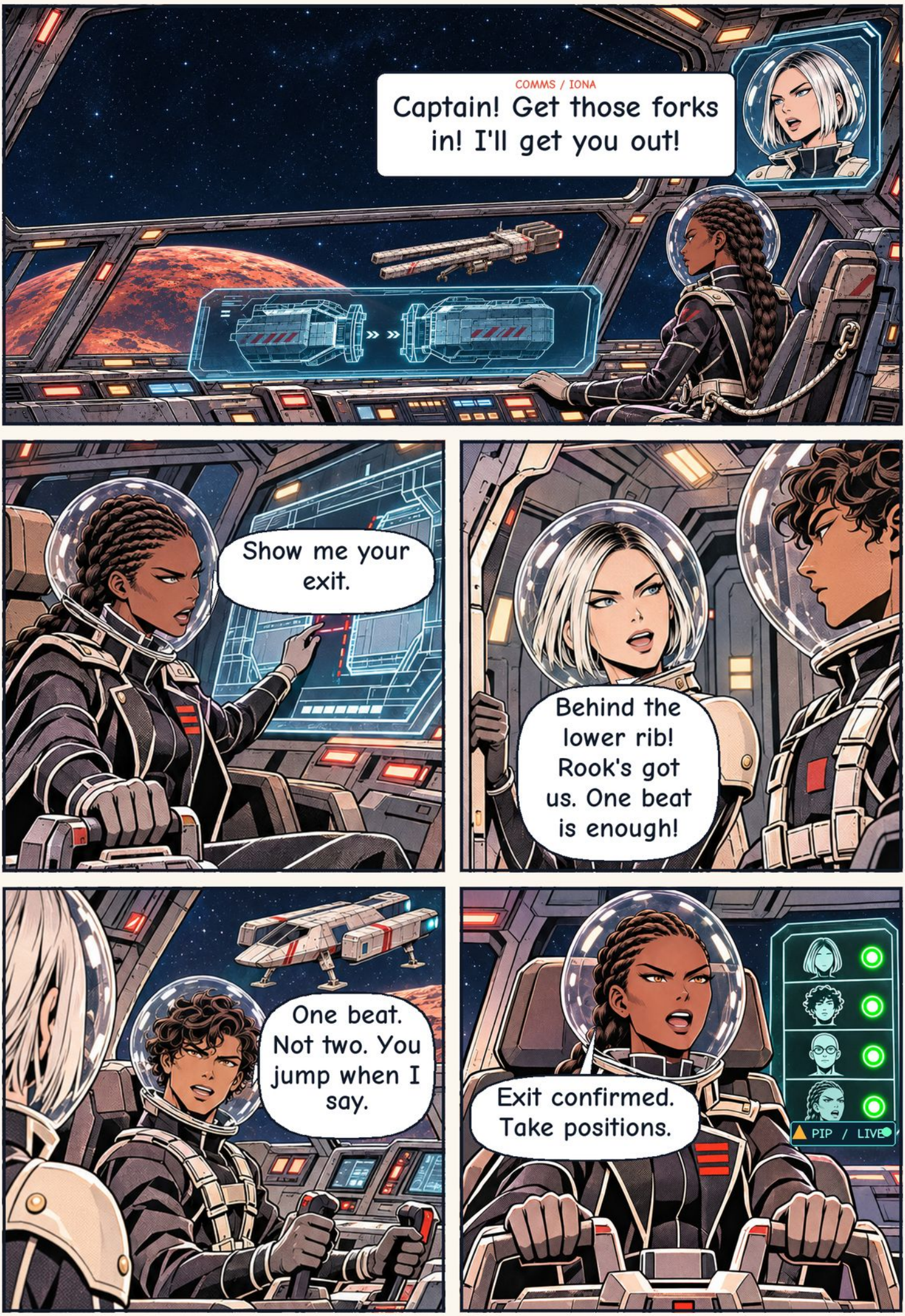

Stay clipped, hotshot! I'll keep the hatch clear!

Cut complete. That was almost a professional manoeuvre.
TWANG

Iona. My line is gone. I cannot reach the rail.

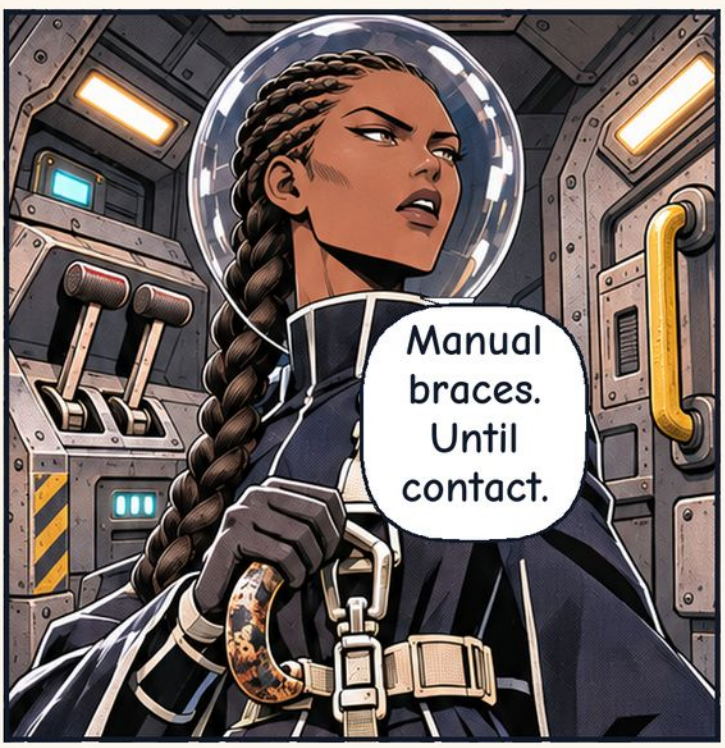
Rook! Eyes on me! Kick off the capsule! Come on!
I hate practical exams. They keep adding extra space.
THUMP
Elbow! Knee! Breathe! Got you! Floor loses again!
Next time we compete, I am choosing a seated sport.


Pip's still shaking. Keep him warm. I'll make this thing behave.
Look. The two faces match the forks we rang at lunch.
Ha! Lunch was training! Rook, tell me you can lift those!
We have a ship built from a spectacularly large fork.
No. I am not pressing that.


COMMS / IONA
Captain! Get those forks in! I'll get you out!
Show me your exit.
Behind the lower rib! Rook's got us. One beat is enough!
One beat. Not two. You jump when I say.
Exit confirmed. Take positions.
PIP / LIVE

VWAAM

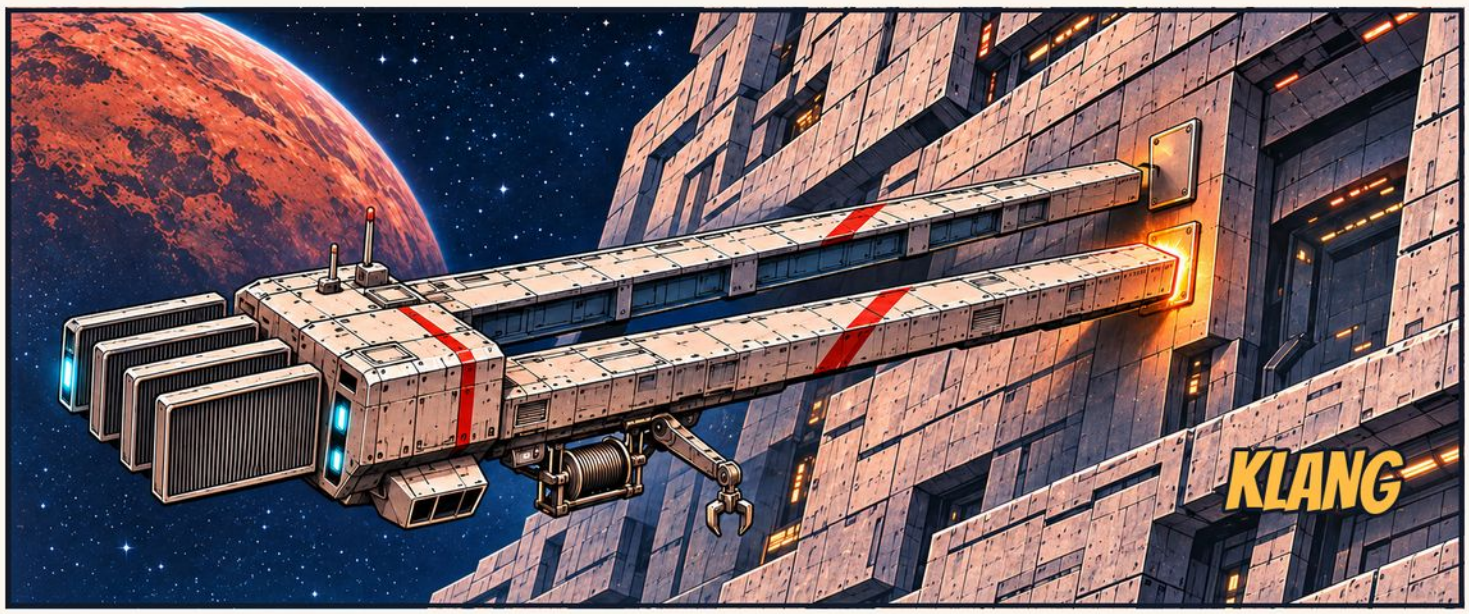
Captain, come over now! Let the ship hold itself!


Manual braces. Until contact.

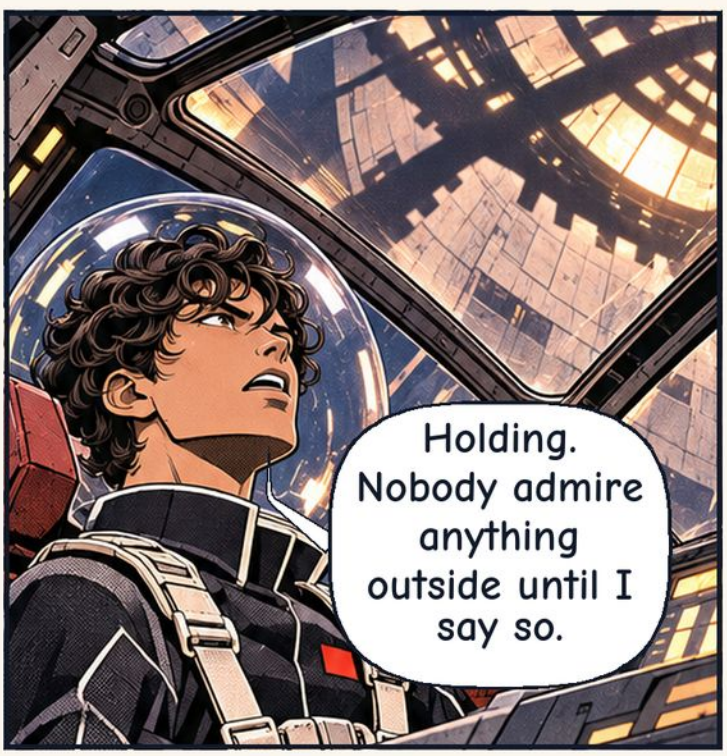
Then I'm staying! You don't get to skip your own rescue!

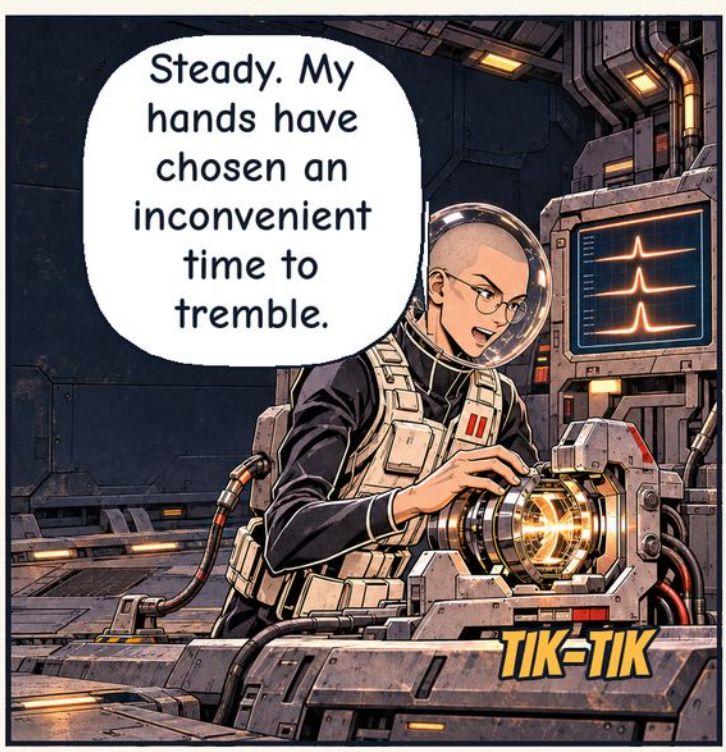
PIP / LIVE
Everyone comes back. Me too.

Hey! Stop leaking! We are busy rescuing our captain!
PSSSH
Last burst. I saved it for exactly this sort of complaint.
Ha! Sealed with dessert! Try doing that with your lunch, Rook!
PFFFT
Captain, the left face is moving. You have three seconds.
Three seconds. Holding steady.

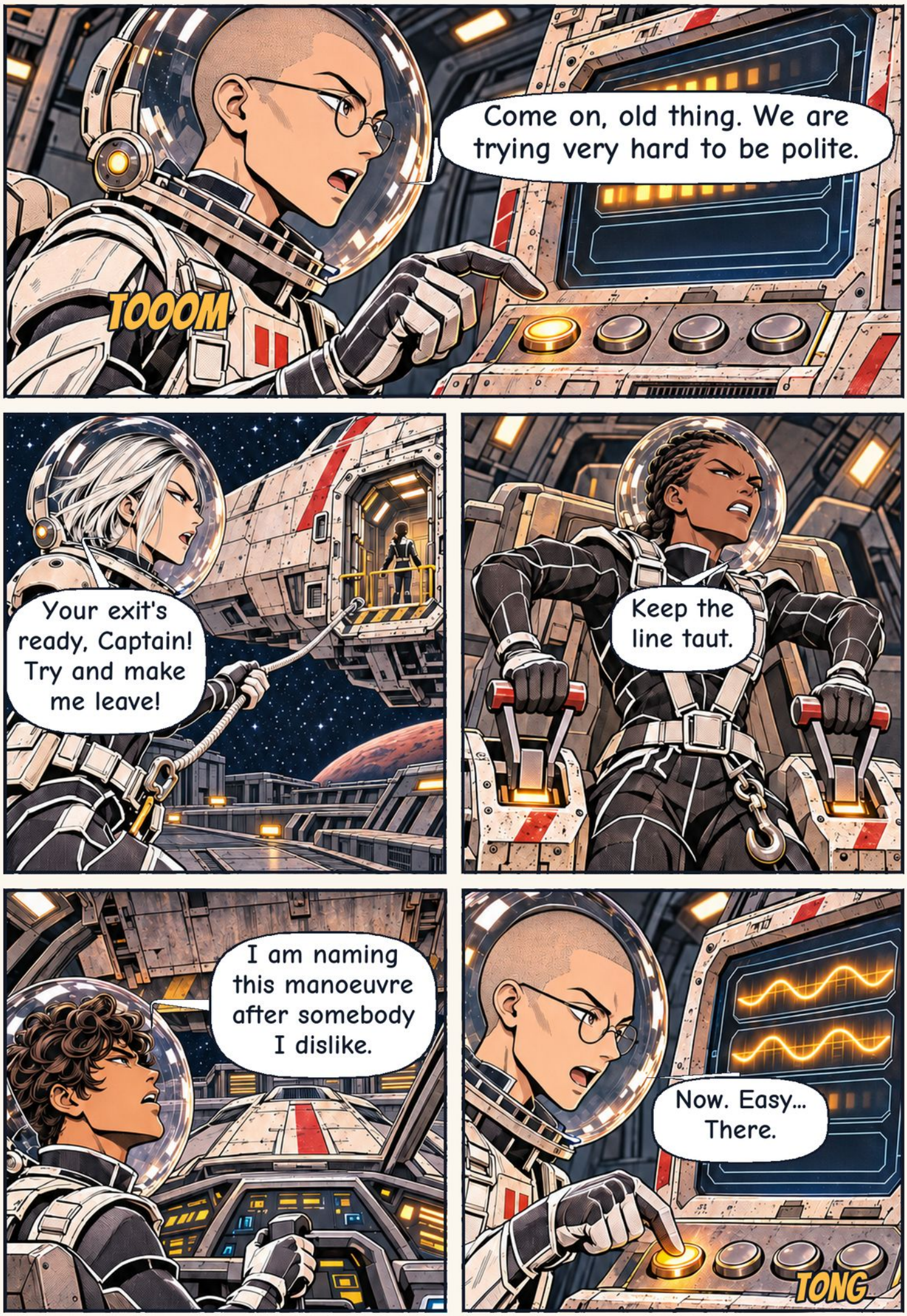

KLANG

Left contact. Keep them sheltered.


Holding. Nobody admire anything outside until I say so.

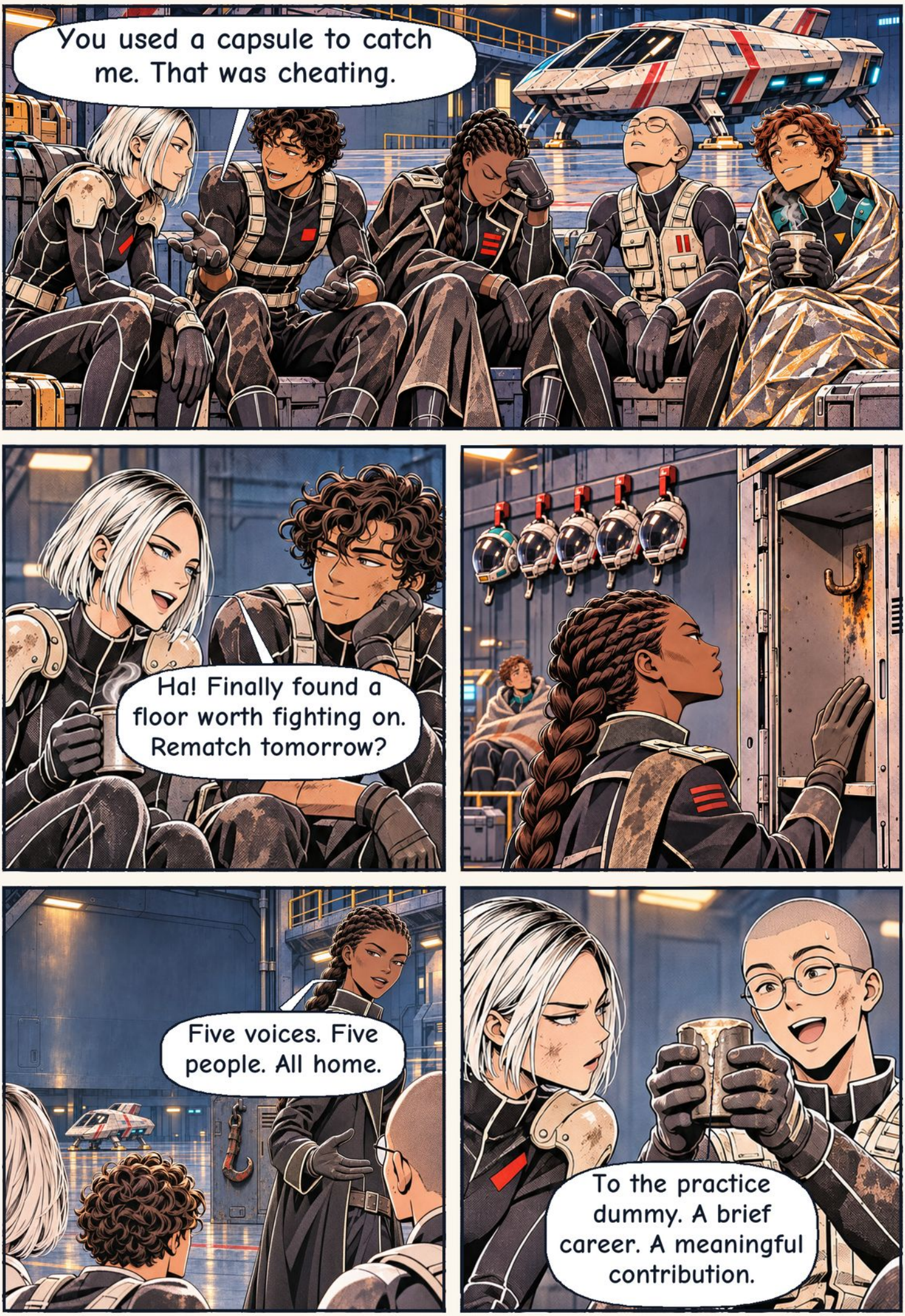

Steady. My hands have chosen an inconvenient time to tremble.
TIK-TIK

COMMS / SERA
Right contact. Braces locked.
KLANG

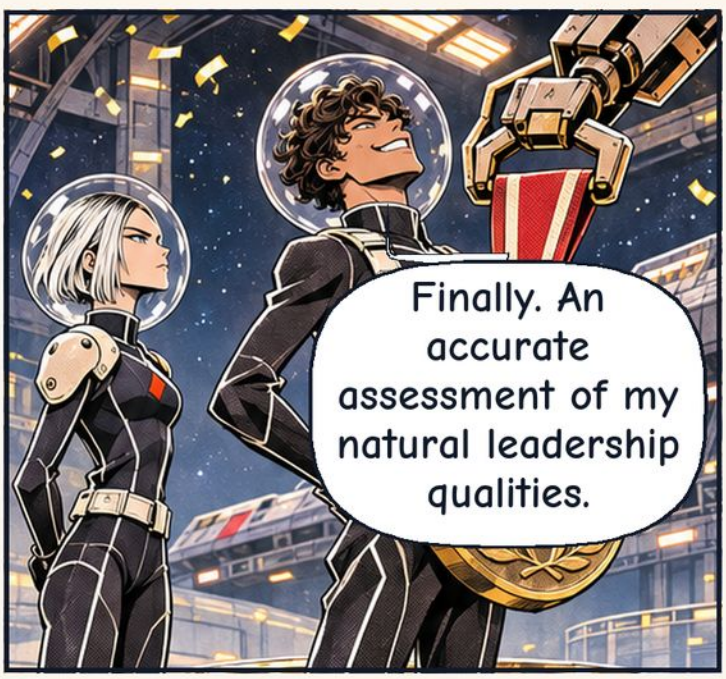

Come on, old thing. We are trying very hard to be polite.
TOOOM
Your exit's ready, Captain! Try and make me leave!
Keep the line taut.
I am naming this manoeuvre after somebody I dislike.
Now. Easy... There.
TONG

VWAAM
COMMS / ROOK
We just hit an ancient machine with a very expensive lullaby.

Braces released. Take me.
Yes! Captain caught! Rook, beat that for a landing!
Everyone attached? I am about to offend the scenery.
VWAAM
KRAKOOM
It heard us. I think it actually heard us.


You used a capsule to catch me. That was cheating.
Ha! Finally found a floor worth fighting on. Rematch tomorrow?
Five voices. Five people. All home.
To the practice dummy. A brief career. A meaningful contribution.

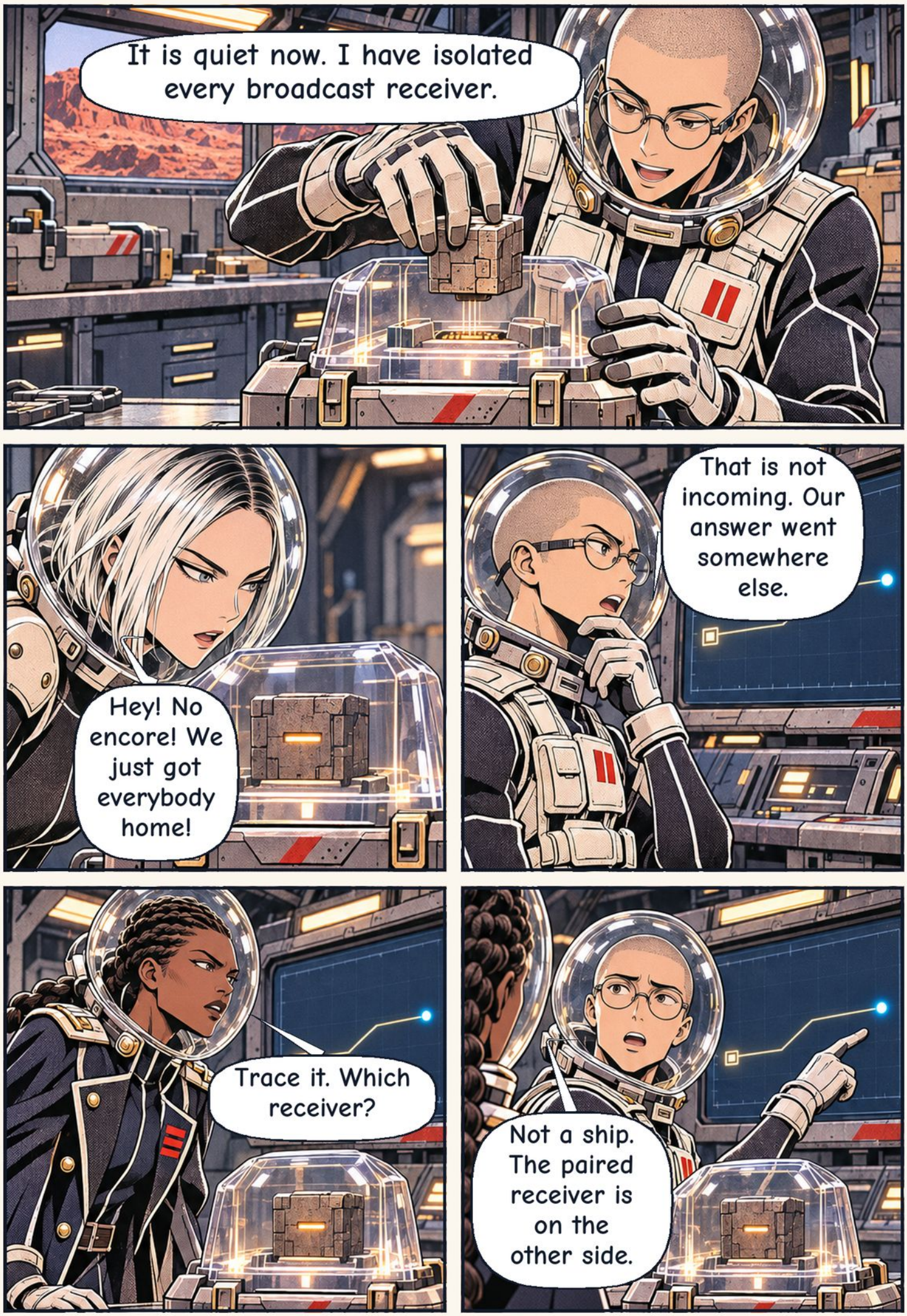
FV
Our cadets have defeated gravity through outstanding personal commitment!


Finally. An accurate assessment of my natural leadership qualities.

That is heavier than the natural leadership qualities advertised.

Elbow! Knee! Breathe! Come on, hero! Beat the medal!

FV
Another tactical hug! The heroes are embracing their achievements.


It is quiet now. I have isolated every broadcast receiver.
Hey! No encore! We just got everybody home!
That is not incoming. Our answer went somewhere else.
Trace it. Which receiver?
Not a ship. The paired receiver is on the other side.

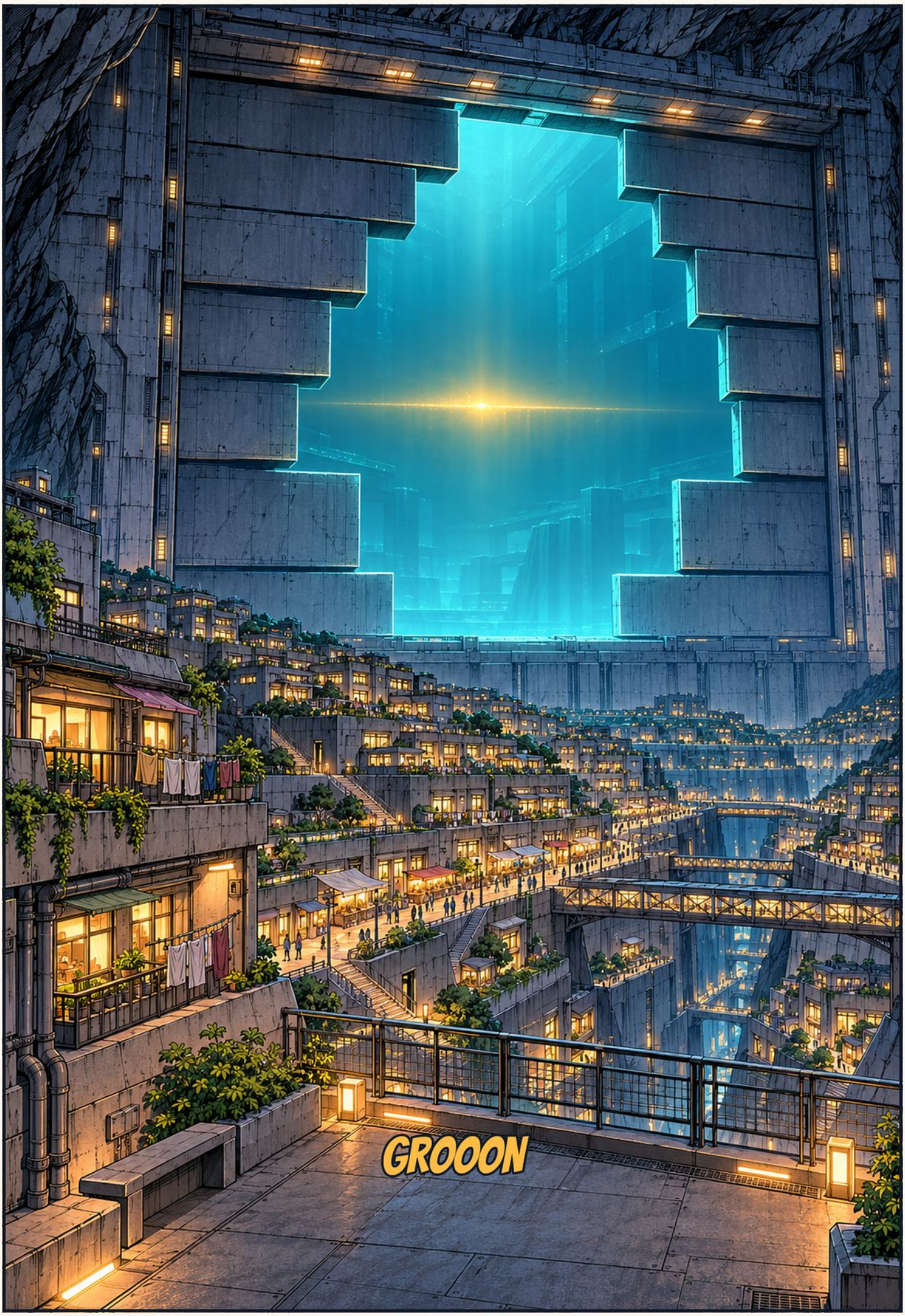
Earth. Confirm the bearing.

Please tell me we have not declared war by humming.

We sent the handshake. Something is opening at the far end.

TIK

SHUNK


GROOON

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NEXT: Volume 2 — Medal of Upright Excellence

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